Knights of the Fright Zone

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
Multi, F/M, M/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra) & Man-at-Arms (He-Man), Adora & Lonnie (She-ra), Adora (She-Ra) & Man-at-Arms (He-Man), Adora & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Man-At-Arms (He-Man), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mortella (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Canon-Typical Violence, Training, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Action, Fluff and Angst, Memory Alteration, Memory Magic, Flipping Defiance Off as We Walk Backwards into Hell, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Lonnie Needs A Hug (She-Ra)

Language:
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Knights of the Fright Zone

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

As Halfmoon reels from the second coup attempt, the Horde continues it's slow attempt to conquer Etheria and Subtheria while training a cadre of expert warriors. First and foremost amongst them is Lonnie but her position is not as secure as she might hope.

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Chapter 1: The First Crack in the Wall

Town Square

Village of Alicor

The Whispering Woods

Etheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

The Town had burned; it was as simple as that. In the early morning light, the Horde had launched their attack and left swathes of the town as a ruin.

Lonnie sat on the wreckage of Grizzlor's command tank, the only real damage the rebel sorcerers and militia managed to deal to the overwhelming Horde force. It was a complete success; her first real experience in the field as the youngest Force Captain in Fright Zone history. Lonnie still thought it was a waste. Her, an infantry division, and one tank could have taken this town, and leaving only half that as a garrison would have held it even against the threat of the rebel sorcerers.

She could handle those, as she had well proven, but Grizzlor wanted to settle an old grudge. So, he had deployed everything in his arsenal, and lost a good command tank, again. One of the sorcerers had gotten close enough to get a single lucky bolt of fire magic into the exhaust and blew the whole tank. Grizzlor was lucky to survive, thrown as he was from the top of the tank where he was shouting orders basically begging to be shot by a sniper.

His active stupidity saved his life, which Lonnie was slowly coming to realize was a standard with Horde Force Captains who got that way by being seemingly too mean to argue with, too cowardly to fight back against people stronger than them (which

was only Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and other Force Captains who had more authority), and too stupid to know when they should be dead.

She sighed, tossing aside another of the 'trophies' she had taken and picking the last one from the small burlap sack. This one was a wand made of what appeared to be the local wood; the last of the sorcerers to die had carried it. He had gone down hard, almost celebrating after blowing up the tank. He hadn't noticed her turn on him, and put a sword through his spine.

Her sword, she looked down at them and kept contemplating, two swords: equal in weight, design, and length. The only difference to anyone's eye was the colouration of the metal: one was good Horde Foundry steel, the other a strange black metal. The latter she had forged with her own hands alongside its now dead sister, twin blades as any Knight trained to be a Moondancer should carry, each designed to focus her power. Now, she had one blade that was her focus, all her strength torn in half by a single action, and another blade, a masterwork.

Three times she had it commissioned by the Horde's smiths and three times she had sent it back for being imperfect. Eventually, she had journeyed down to the Scorpioni enclave—their people were masters of such craft—and found an old smith, offering him extra rations. He had demanded medicine for his family. She had agreed and even performed the healing spells herself, much to Shadow Weaver's chagrin.

The old Scorpioni had come back a week later with a blade that was perfectly balanced, designed to her exacting specification, and could hold a tiny fragment of her power thanks to one of her four gifted shards of the Black Garnet. But despite its perfection, it was not her focus. She could wield it as any Blademaster could, she could even channel lightning through it, but she couldn't carve runic circles into the air with it. It was perfectly imperfect and so she stared down at the collected focus of each sorcerer here—staves and wands and amulets—some of which she could take and melt down to make her own new focus,

but that would take time and, without a proper guide or the secrets of such a ritual, she would always create something equally imperfect. Shadow Weaver had offered to assist her, but her mentor was a cruel woman who Lonnie couldn't trust to not taint such a sacred thing.

Sacred. Since when did Lonnie believe in such things? But she did. This was a Mystacoran ritual; she wouldn't have it done by an exile like Light Spinner. The woman always reacted violently to that name being spoken in her presence but she had heard the story. So, she had to find the right materials and go through the ritual again alone.

Try as she might, remembering that day was difficult. She remembered Isolde, her old swordmaster, taking her to the edge of the Fright Zone, still in her shackles. She remembered water, and a forge made in the open air. Her muscles ached at the memory but, other than that, the day was a blur.

She tossed the wand down into the earth where it stuck like a twig pointing to the sky next to the body of its old master, lying face down in the dirt. Rolling her shoulders, she hopped off the tank and strode into the village proper.

Parts of it were still smouldering, the mayoral hall was gone, as was the sorcerers' quarters—hit by a tank shell on Grizzlor's orders; a smart move that she would have some vengeance for later. She still had a job to do and, since that idiot got himself injured, she was the ranking officer. She checked the health of the men, and stopped by the command tent to grab Grizzlor's tablet with the list of required goods, glaring at the beastman the entire time. He only glared back, his lungs still a mess from the smoke he had inhaled and so unable to voice his no doubt witty commentary on her age, her skill, or anything else he found lacking. She refused to acknowledge any of it. Instead, she collected what she needed and set out.

First was an assessment of the losses. Easy enough there: one command tank and four fatalities on the Horde side as well as

eight more casualties in comparison to nearly thirty fatalities and twice that number in casualties for the Rebellion.

Once all the sorcerers were dead, Lonnie had opened up a path to let the rebels flee, so the fighting would end quicker. Grizzlor was too busy trying to put himself out to countermand that order like he normally would.

She took a stroll around town to assess what was captured—mainly lumber. The town was a tiny, insignificant speck of a thing with only four real notable facts about it: firstly, it was a producer of lumber and had access to one of the mines that collected ore used in the creation of silversteel (not a principle mine but enough to be relevant to the war effort). Secondly, it was close enough to the warfront that it should realistically have been a target of invasion years ago but had been passed over as a military target dozens of times in the last decade. Thirdly, it was a protectorate of the region of Mystacor, guaranteeing at least a token sorcerer presence (the only previous invasion attempt had involved the capture of Isolde and secured her first true teacher). Finally, Grizzlor had been gunning to level the town since before Lonnie had become a teenager, his streak of losing whatever tank he was driving had started here to Isolde, and as a superstitious old fool, he thought taking it would end that streak. The command tank still smoked and sizzled behind her.

Her soldiers had finished their sweep of the town, taking what rebels that hadn't escaped captive, and letting some of the civilians trickle back to their homes. She would run the numbers to ensure there was enough lumber and ore to allow them to rebuild. She wasn't a monster, but the Horde needed its tithe.

Entering into a warehouse, she began to count. It was at times like this she was glad she picked up the trait of keeping pen-and-paper lists. Everyone but Shadow Weaver thought it was outdated, but tablets glitched frequently enough, and she could always transfer the data later. She tallied up crates and boxes until the sun was past its zenith. Only when she had a good count of

the numbers did she leave, grabbing a ration bar and continuing her exploration of the newest village in the Horde's territory.

Shadow Weaver had given her a list of reagents to collect for some experiment with certain promises made in regards to Kyle's long term safety. She filled her bag with a few slivers of the silver ore, she had pilfered the bodies of the sorcerers for trinkets that the old witch would find useful, and was now making her way past the burnt out wreck of the sorcerers' quarters to a small hut off to one side of the village. This was where one of the villagers said the town herbalist lived; it was as good a place as any to start a search for flowers and roots found only in the Whispering Woods.

As she pushed open the door to the small, wooden room, the sunlight streaming through the windows was the only thing lighting the racks of dried plants. The smell of gently burning sage and fresh flowers still beginning the process of drying assaulted her immediately. She swallowed a lump in her throat and wiped her hand over her face, thinking she was sweating, but her eyes came away slightly wet, and she had no idea why. She shook her head once and the feeling passed.

Consulting her list, she began to mindlessly work her way through the shop. Surprisingly, most of what was required for Shadow Weaver's mysterious project was found in the different vials and pots of the small shop. She could recognise the components of a powerful illusion spell. That kind of spell would be dangerous in Shadow Weaver's hands, but what was Lonnie to do? She collected each carefully, making sure not to disturb anything more than was necessary.

As she emerged from the small store, Grizzlor was hobbling over. As he got close, he began to snarl. He was bigger than her—much bigger; physically stronger, too. That wouldn't matter if this came to a fight. She was a Knight and he was just a Champion. He knew it as well as her, but he couldn't be shown to be weak, especially considering how much this one little speck of a town had cost him personally, twice now.

"Have you got what the witch needs?" He loomed over her. He was quite good at looming; not as good as Shadow Weaver, but enough to scare the recruits. She just looked up at him blankly, humming a gentle tune and tapping her fingertips against the hilt of her steel sword. She nodded at the question. "Good." His face suddenly broke into a feral grin. "We'll leave and I'll give the order."

"What order?" Lonnie could tell it would be something vicious—Grizzlor was just that kind of bastard. Executing the prisoners maybe?

"Burning the town. As soon as we're out, the rest of the company are gonna hit it with high explosives. Keeps the Rebellion from taking it back; it's standard operating procedure." He was grinning; clearly, he enjoyed this part of the job. Lonnie was almost sickened to see she could understand the logic.

"Belay that, this is a vital resource and the people here are a protectorate." His grin fell as she spoke. "They are under my protection, and the Horde will make certain guarantees of their protection."

"Listen here, you're new, I'll forgive you, but these kind of places are best burnt and forgotten." His voice took on a condescending tone. She sighed at him.

"Force Captain Grizzlor, do you see this?" She pointed at her badge; his eyes didn't shift from her face. "This here marks me out as Knight Captain Lonnie Leor, a position granted to me by Hordak, and this mission is mine, considering you managed to fuck it up so badly last time. So, I say we leave a garrison in the town, find out if the mayor is still alive, and get them to sign the normal protectorate treaty."

"I don't take orders from a kid who thinks that just cause they own a fancy sword they're a damn Champion," Grizzlor growled, his hand lowering to his mace. He blinked, and one sword was hovering an inch above his wrist while the other was touching his

throat, a few hairs from his beard drifting gently down to the ground.

Lonnie's expression barely shifted, her hands as steady as rocks. With the slightest pressure, she could cut his throat and end the illustrious career of Force Champion Grizzlor. "I don't think I'm a Champion, Grizzlor. I'm the Knight of the Horde. I could kill you and tell everyone your fuck ups cost you your life, burning to death in a tank. Hell, I could give them a charred corpse. This is my mission. You follow my orders. Is that clear? Or do I need to fill out a 'killed in action' report for you?"

"That fancy title won't protect you forever," he started, then felt the pressure on his jugular. "But fine, it's your command, Knight Captain. You give the orders, I'll get the boys to pack up." She sheathed the blades in one smooth motion then waited for him to leave. She hummed to herself tunelessly. That could have gone worse, she was reasonably certain she could take Grizzlor, but it could get messy. As she watched the tank companies began to roll around back towards the Fright Zone, she went in search of whoever was in charge in this town that was still alive.

Hordak's Throne Room

Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

Lord Hordak stood at the top of the stairs that led to his throne. He had called a meeting to discuss the ongoing war effort on greater Etheria. Several projects of his were now functional and it was coming time to bring the full might of the Horde against the Rebellion. Lonnie felt a swell of pride; she had made

it, Knight Captain, a unique title, and the youngest Captain in Horde history, called to a proper war cabinet.

Shadow Weaver, Mortella, and Callix weren't in attendance; some big push in Subtheria required direct attention from the frontline command center. Which meant only the commanders in charge of the Etherian war effort were present: a dozen or so Force Captains and Champions all bickering and arguing about what needed priority. It took all her resolve to not join the arguing. They were all idiots but she could watch and listen. Slowly she had a plan forming in her head of how to take enough of the territory around the hidden Kingdom of Mystacor to be able to find it and launch an attack but, to do so, she would need more authority than she currently had, and more sway to keep it from Shadow Weaver's attention until it was too late for her to do anything about it.

Force Captain Octavia was watching her, her one good eye staring across at her. She still hadn't forgiven Lonnie for the deaths of her crew on recreation leave a few years ago, and the older woman could hold a grudge. But, as stupid as Octavia was, she had some cunning, and attacking Lonnie while she held both the favour of Lord Hordak and Shadow Weaver was essentially signing her own death certificate.

Eventually, Lord Hordak silenced the room and began to take individual reports. Each person in the room reported successes and blamed others in the room for their failures; Grizzlor even tried to direct blame onto her. Eventually, she was called forward. Kneeling before Lord Hordak, she bowed her head.

"Lord Hordak, I am pleased to report that the town of Alicor was taken with minimal casualties and will now serve as a protectorate of the Horde. The force requisitioned to me acquitted itself well. A small force has been left to garrison the town to ensure order and that the proper tithe is collected from the new mayor. I have given them a year to rebuild before we start demanding payments." She spoke as clear as she could, not

deflecting blame as the others did. She would be better than them.

"Excellent work, Knight Captain. I expect a full report on my desk by the end of the day." He gestured and she stepped back into the crowd, emphasizing her achievements to make Grizzlor look petty. The meeting continued for half an hour more before Lord Hordak dismissed them. As they all turned to leave. "Not you, Knight Captain." She froze. Had she made some mistake, something to get Lord Hordak's attention negatively?

She turned slowly, and sank to one knee. "Yes, Lord Hordak?" He took his seat on the throne, and leaned backwards, slowly closing his eyes. He looked tired, almost ill.

"I suffer far too many fools on this backwater." He only muttered it, but Lonnie caught the words. He then spoke up, "Knight Captain, you have shown an aptitude for… restraint. There is an old series of tunnels that connects the Fright Zone to Subtheria. One such tunnel exists at the edge of the foundry dumping grounds. We have known about it for some time but Shadow Weaver's newest gambit may lead to… reprisal. You are to take a force, the lumber you have secured, requisition metal from the foundry, and build a fortification over that cave system. We cannot have it sealed nor can we leave it undefended. I give you this as your second task to prove yourself to me."

"Thank you, Lord Hordak, for another mission so soon after the first. I will not fail you." She bowed her head low, and he dismissed her. She walked for a few minutes, sending a few messages to begin organizing for her next mission. She knew very little about constructing a fortress; she would have to do research on that.

Her feet took her back to the old barracks, the place she had grown up. Kyle and Rogelio were still there, alongside a new squad of cadets. As she entered, everyone saluted, even the pair she had come here for. She scowled around the room and the cadets shrunk back. She shifted her glare over to Kyle and Rogelio

who exchanged looks. In her most authoritative voice she said, “You two, come with me!” and stalked out of the room. The cadets scrambled to get out of her way, many of them sending pitying looks at Kyle and Rogelio.

The two followed her out into the corridor. She walked just far enough that the cadets wouldn’t hear anything before she turned and leapt, grabbing Rogelio and pulling him tight against her, laughing. The taller lizardfolk lifted her up without any apparent effort and Kyle leaned against the wall. “Did you see their faces?” He was laughing to himself.

[[It went well, your hunt?]] Rogelio hissed out directly against her ear, holding her close to him. [[You proved yourself to the Dark One and the Lord?]] She rested her head against his shoulder and closed her eyes.

“Yeah, big guy, it went well. Got to kill some sorcerers, showed them that the rebels aren’t the only ones who can fight like they can.” She chuckled into his shoulder and he rumbled something low and bassy like a laugh. “Pulled some strings, too. Shadow Weaver needed materials collected and I’ve leveraged it for something I want.” She tapped his shoulder and he gently let her down to the ground. “I’ve got both of you transferred. Rogelio your joining my heavy infantry, and Kyle, I’ve got the transfer orders to send you to R&D where you’ll be safe. You can count on that.”

She could still remember that dreadful night where Kyle lay on a medical bed barely able to breath. R&D was one of the few divisions directly under Lord Hordak’s purview; attacking someone who did good work under it was a one-way ticket to Beast Island, assuming you survived to make it to the transport. If anyone was stupid enough to go after Kyle, well, they wouldn’t make it to the transport. “Plus, my new mission will keep me in the Fright Zone for the next little while; it’ll keep us close together.”

Kyle was grinning like an idiot and threw himself at her such that, if she wasn’t the skilled warrior that she was, she would

have dropped him. As it was, she caught him and gave him a twirl for good measure. She finished the twirl with a quick kiss and let him down. He was as red as his shirt when she let go.

"Alright, you two, get packed up. Transfer orders should come in at 0600. I want you transferred to your new quarters and out of this hole as soon as possible." Her voice was light. "Then meet me at rec room 3, I've got to write a report but I'll meet you there in an hour." This was the best she had felt in years. Both of them nodded and rushed off. Kyle would grab her an extra ration bar.

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Ten Years After the Coup Attempt

She threw off her heavy Horde jacket as she walked into the small room. The Prisoner, Duncan, had turned this place into some kind of temple to training. If Lonnie was honest, she didn't understand it, nor did she particularly care. The man was one of the best fighters she had ever seen, and the only one she could regularly train against. He was good; even after a year, she couldn't land more than a glancing hit on him. She needed to get better, to be able to beat him. If he broke free, it would be her responsibility to capture and return him.

He was seated at the moment, chewing thoughtfully on a grey ration bar. He nodded to her once when she entered, the chains of bloodsteel around his throat, wrist, and legs clinking gently.

It had been just over a week since the invasion of Alicor. She had only managed to get in a few hours of rec time with the boys before being thrown into the logistics of building, arming, and

training a force to man a fortress over an entrance to Subtheria. Apparently, there was some complex politics over the hole in the ground she had been tasked to defend. She had barely gotten more than the four hours of mandated training time each day, and that was cutting into her sleep. Today, though, she had a few hours free between settled reports and the actual construction now underway, as well as Kyle and Rogelio actually getting settled. She finally had a chance to come down and spar.

The older man shifted to his feet. He was wearing a white compression shirt and forest green trousers, something easily acquirable from the quartermaster and without Horde insignia. He moved with an uncanny grace despite his size; he was a warrior through and through and every muscle in his body responded like a warrior. “You look tired, Knight Captain.”

She shrugged, approaching the weapons stand and taking two short lengths of cut wood made to match the length of the blades. “Being a Knight and a captain is exhausting work, but no one else is going to do it.” He looked at her with something like pity; she hated that look. “But I have a few hours free,” she tested the weight of the two blades in her hands, “and I need the practice.”

“Sword, staff, fist, or mace?” he asked. She was holding her blades so it wouldn’t be fists but giving her the choice meant she could continually improve. She had seen him fight with all four, and he was lethal in every way, but the mace was clearly his weapon of choice. The sword would give her the most form practice, as it was with sword against sword, but she needed to see where her weaknesses were.

“Mace. I want you to really push me.” She turned and strode towards the center of the room, her own blade and focus left with her coat. She reached up and removed all but one of the Black Garnet shards from where they were braided into her hair. She couldn’t go without at least one on her now, but the others would join her gear in the corner.

She turned back to Duncan. He was standing in his casual pose. His strange wooden sword—a *kiari* she had heard him call it—was still at his belt but in his hands was a wooden cudgel, as close to a mace as he could get without giving him a lethal weapon. She smiled and, without a count, they began.

They fell into the dance of combat, Lonnie forced onto the defensive far more often than she would like, but giving as good as she could get: for every two or three bruises she took, she scored one back. Not exactly equal, but certainly better than a year ago. After a dozen minutes of silence between them except for the *smack* of wood on flesh or the *crack* of wood against wood, both were beginning to sweat. She could feel the pull of magic, the instinct honed into her by this fighting style and Shadow Weaver to cast a spell, not to wait for an opening but to create one. She resisted that urge; if she was ever cut off from her magic—like she often would be if she didn't get another focus—then she would need to be able to win without relying on such tricks.

Eventually, the clash of wood broke the two of them apart and they stepped backwards, examining each other and themselves. Both now sported nasty bruises growing on their flesh. If they had weapons of war rather than of training, both would likely have lost limbs and be bleeding to death. As it was, Duncan opened his mouth and said, "A good fight, I will say. You have gotten even better since our last duel." She shrugged and winced.

"Not good enough. A Mystacoran mage nearly took my head off with a blade of ice in Alicor." She stepped back into stance and moved forward slowly, keeping her feet loose. "I can't let them get that close again."

"Any battle comes with the risk of death," he said calmly, a fact he had accepted a lifetime ago. "You can only mitigate the risks. I am sure many mages of Mystacor are now desperately trying to find a way to survive you." She grinned at that, and he used that opportunity to lung forwards. She turned the blow aside with a twisting parry from the wooden blade.

“Compliments won’t distract me, Assassin.” She had taken to calling him that, at first in anger and growing into a compliment of his skills over the years. She had learned to focus through distractions years before ever meeting the strange Knight who claimed to be from another world.

“And yet, you seem to be distracted.” His mace kept whistling through empty air as she dodged and parried, but an opening was never truly present. “So, if it is not by my efforts, what is it that distracts you?”

“I will not speak about it with you, Duncan.” She twisted to one side and put her blades low in a guard. “As much as I like and respect you, Duncan, you are my prisoner, not my ally. I don’t doubt one day you’ll try to escape, and I’ll have to either kill or capture you again.”

There was a momentary sadness that passed over him, then his expression hardened. “That is true, Knight Captain, but you will not be the target of my ire. Instead, it would be that witch. One day, I swear I will kil—” His words were cut off by lightning arcing along the cuffs. She stepped back into a defensive stance as the lights in the room flickered. Taking a deep breath she turned back to the entrance of the room.

Standing in the darkened doorway was the figure of his hatred, tall and imposing. Shadows clung to her as she floated into the room. The susurrus of whispering voices from the shadows that seemed omnipresent around her. She hovered closer to Lonnie, and rested one hand on her cheek. Almost motherly while coiling serpents of lightning arced over Duncan as he grunted in pain. It almost looked like he was going to speak as Shadow Weaver gently cupped her face.

“Congratulations, Lonnie. A fine job you have done in Alicor, both in securing the town and the materials I need. I knew it was wise to put my trust in you.” She retracted the hand and Lonnie almost chased it. “Please leave me to speak with the prisoner. There are expectations I must impose upon him, and it is best you

are not present for such a conversation.” She looked over at Duncan who was glaring at the witch. “Take a few hours to rest. I will have a new task for you come morning.”

Lonnie gulped down the heavy feeling in her throat. It wasn’t fear; she wasn’t frightened. Taking one last look at Duncan, she nodded once to him and he met her eyes and she could see a grim resolve in them. Turning back to Shadow Weaver, she saluted. “Of course, Shadow Weaver. I will retire to my quarters.” She gathered her things as quickly as she could as Shadow Weaver turned her attention on Duncan. She turned and marched out to the sound of crackling lightning.

She quickly made her way back to her quarters. The small room was dark, her few furnishings taken from the quartermaster and now a few pieces from Alicor made the room her own beyond a normal Force Captain's chambers. It was empty except for a figure standing in the center of the room in full combat dress staring head cocked to the side like a cat into a full length mirror, a treasure she had recovered from Alicor’s mayoral manor. Lonnie snarled. This was her private chambers, no one could get in without the passcode, which only her, Kyle, and Rogelio had. She put one hand on the hilt of her sword and stepped forward. “This is a private chamber, soldier. You are not welcome here. Leave before I report this to your CO.”

The figure turned to face her. They were in a female cadet uniform that looked like it barely fit, the helmet was fixed in place and through the distorted audio, an almost familiar voice crackled, “What, get promoted to Knight and suddenly I’m too good for you?” The cadet gave a salute that was way too sharp for the sarcastic tone.

“I don’t know who you are, cadet, and that sounds dangerously close to insubordination.” She stepped closer to the cadet, who was a few inches taller than her. “Remove your helmet!” she gave the order in her normal sharp commander's tone.

The figure cocked her head at her again, then shrugged, reaching up to unclasp the helmet. “Geeze, Lonnie. A few years of training and you forget everything. Did that magic mess up your head? You aren’t going mad like a Princess, are you?”

The figure had removed their helmet and held it gently under one arm, they were a teenager around Lonnie’s age. She had a shock of blonde hair cropped almost to the skull at the sides of her head and only a few inches longer on top. Pinprick scars marked her ears and on the inside of her nose, and a pair of mirrored lichtenberg scars ran down the sides of her temples right down to under the lid of her eyes. Her eyes were a blue grey—which was remarkably familiar—though rimmed with red like she had been crying, all freshly healed with poorly done healing magic.

She could feel herself stammering, her brain running directly into a wall. Shadow Weaver getting a secret project, Shadow Weaver down in Subtheria, Shadow Weaver getting components for a powerful illusion?

“Adora?”

One Week After Adora’s Abduction

Chapter 2: Adora of the Horde

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

> Adora chats with Lonnie before meeting her new C.O. and teacher.

Adora's(?) Quarters

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Week After Adora's Abduction

"Adora?" Lonnie asked, shock and disbelief written across her face.

"That's me!" Adora said with a casual smirk. "Jeez, Lonnie, it's only been a couple weeks since we last saw each other but you look like you've seen a ghost. Are you feeling alright?" Adora adopted a faux concerned expression as she closed the distance between them and started to check Lonnie's eyes. "Do you have brain damage?"

"How— But— You—" Lonnie batted Adora's hands away before taking a deep breath, seemingly to gather herself. She hummed tunelessly for a brief moment and rolled her shoulders before saying, "Right. Just… surprised to see you in my quarters, is all. How've you been, Adora?"

Adora tilted her head quizzically. But these were *her* quarters? There was probably just some snafu with scheduling since they

weren’t going to be hers for much longer anyway.

“Eh, you know how Horde life is. Just finished up some commando training and now Shadow Weaver's going to have me train with the prisoner to become a Champion.” Adora smirked again. “Or, who knows, maybe I'll become a Knight as well.” She walked up to Lonnie and threw one arm around her shoulders before gesturing with her other hand as though spreading out the words. “Lonnie and Adora, Knights of the Fright Zone. Has a nice ring to it, don't you think?”

Lonnie chuckled as she playfully elbowed Adora in the side, making her remove her arm. “Don't get too ahead of yourself, Cadet. I worked my ass off to become the first Knight of the Fright Zone.”

Adora pouted. “Hey, I've been working my ass off, too; I don't think I could take you in a fight yet but I'd sure as hell make you work for that win. Besides, isn't that what we promised each other? You and me. Standing at the top so we can take care of Kyle and Rogelio?”

Adora remembered that day well. It was just after she had used her magic for the first—and, so far, *only*—time in order to save Kyle's life. The two of them had hunkered down someplace private after that in order to decompress and that's when they promised two things: to always have each other's back and to get strong enough to where no one would even *think* about hurting their boys again. (Even though Adora very much wasn't into guys like Lonnie was, she still considered Kyle and Rogelio to be her boys.)

Lonnie nodded a few times as she said with a smile, “Yeah. The terrible duo together again and making it everyone else’s problem.” She lightly punched Adora’s shoulder. “You better train hard with the prisoner, Adora; I’m not gonna wait up for you.”

Adora laughed and went to respond only to suddenly freeze. Her hair stood on end as she was hit by the faint smell of decay

and death and heard the susurrus of a thousand voices almost beyond her range of hearing. The presence made her heart beat wildly in her chest, made her eyes slightly widen, made a cold sweat break out all over her body, and made her struggle to keep her breathing even.

"You okay, Adora?" Lonnie asked, clearly concerned by Adora's abrupt change of mood but Adora ignored her. Instead, she spun around and faced toward the door, standing at attention.

Mere moments later, the door opened and in glided Shadow Weaver. The lights seemed to dim and the air grew colder as her presence filled the room until it was almost suffocating.

Adora didn't understand why she was having this reaction. Sure, every sane person other than Lord Hordak was at least a little afraid of Shadow Weaver but this was *beyond* fear. Something in Adora was screaming, almost *begging* her to run as far away from her commanding officer as possible. To run and run and run and keep running until her legs gave out from exhaustion. Until she found a warm, quiet place to curl up. Until she go—

Adora suppressed a wince as her head suddenly started killing her. What had she been thinking about, again?

"Ah, good. I see that you've reunited with Adora," Shadow Weaver said as Lonnie snapped to attention. "Adora shall be staying in the Dark Temple for the foreseeable future. Her location and training are top secret so you are not to breathe a word of this to anything. Understand?"

Lonnie snapped off a salute. "Yes, ma'am!"

"Good. Adora, come with me." As Shadow Weaver turned and started leaving, Adora looked at Lonnie and gave her a tight smile and small wave before quickly following after, falling in place to the left and three paces behind.

Adora didn't understand why her assignment was top secret. The Dark Temple was practically *filled* with people training to

become Champions just like she was and *their* status wasn't top secret! She knew better than to voice her confusion, however; it wasn't the right time or place to take any sort of action.

Adora followed silently and patiently as Shadow Weaver led her into the mess hall of the Dark Temple. Adora quickly took stock of everyone and everything present, her eyes flickering about without missing a single detail as she associated voices and scents with faces where she could. In her mind's eye, she was already envisioning the best way to go about taking out anyone and everyone here.

Why did she feel like she was in a room full of potential enemies? The Horde wasn't the friendliest place in the world but it wasn't *that* bad, right?

Well, at least Adora's rampant paranoia felt more justified with regards to two people who she vaguely recognized as Mortella and Octavia. The former looked at her like she was something nasty that she had stepped on while the latter looked shocked at first but that shock quickly gave way to roiling hatred.

Shadow Weaver then led her to a particular table at which sat a Scorpioni woman that looked vaguely familiar to Adora. She was very tall and broadly built with short, white hair. Despite looking dangerous (and no doubt *being* dangerous), Adora couldn't help but think that she was friend-shaped and thus wasn't already planning how to take her out in a fight.

"A moment of your time, Force Captain Scorpia?" Shadow Weaver "requested" in a level voice. Despite the general din of the place, her voice was still easily heard.

Scorpia quickly stood up at attention, the carapace on her arms and legs clacking as they hit each other. "Ma'am, yes, ma'am. What can I do for you?" she asked, having to project her voice somewhat. Her voice was surprisingly upbeat and she sounded eager to please to Adora's ears.

"Force Captain, this is my ward and student, Adora. Make her your responsibility. You will get her settled later. For now, she must meet another new teacher. I believe the bunk over yours is empty?"

Scorpia smiled at Adora, her expression oddly yet delightfully open and honest. "Very happy to, Shadow Weaver! I can come find her later, if you want? I know you're busy and Special Training orientation is important! I have the folder and the manual, and I can give her my old map!"

Shadow Weaver waved her off. "I will ensure she finds you. Consider her the first member of your squad, Force Captain."

This somehow only served to make Scorpia's smile widen further. Adora's initial impression of Scorpia being friend-shaped seemed very accurate. "Yes, ma'am! I'll make sure we won't disappoint you! We'll do our absolute best for you, won't we, Adora?"

Adora nodded once, smiling back at her new C.O. "Right!" Scorpia's eyes seemed to *sparkle* with excitement and Adora was pretty sure that she was suppressing a squeal.

"Very well. Thank you, Force Captain. Come, Adora."

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Week After Adora's Abduction

Adora wasn't entirely sure what she expected with regards to her new training but everything about this situation was *not* it.

For starters, she was to be taught by the infamous prisoner who nearly killed Lord Hordak a few years back, Duncan. That alone would have been weird enough but Duncan acted like he *knew* her, like he had been searching for her for years and years only to suddenly find her, but he wasn't permitted to say anything due to the magics in his slave collar sealing his words.

(For some reason, thinking about that collar too much made Adora vaguely upset for reasons beyond the obvious. Thinking about it always made her head hurt, though, so she didn't think about it.)

Then he decided to test Adora's skill level via a simple sparring match. Adora had picked up a hand-and-a-half sword and Duncan had picked up one of his own. He then did a weird bow towards her which she had unthinkingly copied before settling into her guard stance. Then Duncan called for the start and things became *interesting.*

The bout had been swift and fierce, their practice blades meeting each other almost as mirrors as they practically flowed around each other. Duncan had been shocked by this but his shock didn't make him falter in the slightest.

It only took three exchanges for Adora to realize that she was almost certainly going to lose; her chances of victory weren't zero but they were close enough. She wasn't terribly bothered by this realization, however, and merely shifted her goal from winning to lasting as long as possible while scoring as many glancing blows as she could.

It took nearly five minutes for Duncan to land his first clean hit. Sure, she had taken so many glancing blows that, had he been using a real sword, she would have faltered *much* sooner but that wasn't important. What *was* important was that she had managed to score eleven glancing blows of her own.

"You are surprisingly skilled; someone has clearly already been teaching you *kirith,"* Duncan said after he called off the bout. He

was breathing a bit heavier than normal which Adora also took as a win. As for herself, while she was breathing harder than Duncan was, she also knew that she could have kept it up for *much* longer if she had to.

"Who was it that tau—" Duncan's question was cut off as the collar (Don't think about it.) constricted his throat again. After a moment of him choking, it finally loosened its grip, letting him shake his head with a weary sigh.

Adora wasn't stupid; she knew what question he had been about to ask. Despite that, however, she didn't answer the question—she *couldn't.* Duncan was a prisoner who had tried to assassinate Lord Hordak. Information as sensitive as the details of some of the best training one can get in the Horde wasn't something that he needed to know.

"Thank you," Adora said instead, addressing the first thing that he had said. "I worked really hard to get to where I am but I still clearly have a lot to learn."

Duncan nodded slowly, a pleased and proud expression on his face. "Indeed you do but not as much as I initially thought. That being said, we're still going to go back to the basics first. I doubt that you are but I want to make sure that there aren't any flaws in your fundamentals before we move on to more advanced movements and techniques."

Adora nodded her agreement. "On a foundation of strong stone must a house be built lest it fall to the storm. A life, too, must be upheld by strong convictions lest it be easily swayed."

Duncan nodded slowly, a thoughtful expression on his face. "Wise words. Now, get in your guard stance and let us begin."

The Barracks

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Eleven Days After Adora's Abduction

Scorpria wasn't entirely sure what to make of her newest (and first!) squad member. She was an absolutely wonderful person and was a hugger just like her (a fact that made Scorpia *incredibly* happy) but there was just something… *off* about her.

Adora very much reminded Scorpia of a cat. She walked almost completely silently and with effortless grace; her balance was impeccable (she was shoved from behind once and Scorpia had watched as she had flowed with the movements as if moving forward was her own choice); her hearing, sense of smell, and night vision were *way* better than just about anyone else that Scorpia knew (yet she was still afraid of the dark; Scorpia had gotten her a battery-operated lamp to help with that); she would tilt her head just so whenever she was curious or confused; her blinking was sporadic and purposeful…

More than all of that, however, was the weird, faraway look that Adora would randomly get sometimes. Scorpia had no idea what was causing it but it was vaguely sad. (She had asked a couple times and Adora had just been confused and said that she hadn't really been thinking of anything—Scorpia had believed her.)

As if all of that weren't enough on its own, Scorpia had accessed Adora's service history and medical records only to discover that the former was suspiciously normal and the latter was almost completely redacted. *No one,* not even her, had a service record that clean and bland and almost her entire medical history being redacted made the files almost completely useless.

Needless to say, all of this added up to make a *very* confused and concerned Scorpia.

But there was also nothing she could really do about any of it. Adora's weird habits were something that Scorpia knew Adora wouldn't be able to explain even if she asked (most people can't really explain their habits) and as for the records? While her service record was suspicious, investigating it without Shadow Weaver finding out *and* while keeping up with her regular duties would be impossible. For the medical records, she could and *would* ask Shadow Weaver about those—they kinda made it hard for her to do her job—but she'd have to wait for a while in order to show that she was a good C.O. for Adora. Once she proved her worth, *then* she could start asking questions.

As Scorpia sat and watched Adora and Duncan (who was also super nice!) train (it was *amazing* how quickly and smoothly they could move), she couldn't help but ponder all of these things. She very much liked Adora and was quickly coming to consider her a friend. Scorpia was the kind of woman who looked out for those she cared about (and even those she didn't, albeit to a lesser degree) so she wanted to help take care of Adora.

Scorpia's thoughts—and the training with Adora stopping first as she noticed before anyone else—came to a halt as the telltale signs that heralded Shadow Weaver's arrival started to become apparent. Adora and Scorpia both faced the door and stood at attention while Duncan looked somewhere between bored and angry.

When Shadow Weaver entered the room, she said something that made Scorpria's eyes widen and her jaw drop in shock.

"Adora, come with me. It's time to start your training in the tomb."

Chapter 3: Night in the Dark

Chapter Summary

Adora experiences a few days of pure horror from being in the Fright Zone as her training ramps up.

Chapter Notes

▶ Content Warning:

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Black Garnet Chamber

Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Twelve Days After Adora's Abduction

There was one thing that Adora knew was fundamentally true: if you wanted to gain something, you had to accept the pain of it. From the headaches that came from multiple repeated classroom lessons, the aching joints and bruises of training with Cobalt or Duncan, and the painful experience of trying (and failing) to make friends in the Horde, nothing was gained without pain. She held tight to that belief, a guiding star, as she lay twitching on the floor, spasming as ruby lightning arced off of her muscles.

She took in a shuddering breath and tried to force herself to her feet. Her hair was frizzed, still holding some static from the painful blast of Shadow Weaver's Black Garnet-infused magic. She had failed to deflect it, failed even to detect it. These were all lessons she was supposed to have mastered. She could remember a gentle… a stern… a harsh voice teaching her how to reach for

the magic within her. She had no idea where that magic came from, only that it existed; a great, almost bottomless pool of light. Shadow Weaver was trying to teach her how to access it, truly gaining control. She had memories of wielding it before but it felt distant, like trying to remember something you only did in a dream. Training is what mattered—finding a balance, as Shadow Weaver put it.

She kept her breathing steady as she rose to her feet, the calmest thing about her, just like Duncan and ~~Ask~~Cobalt had taught her. The mistress of the Black Garnet stood over her, hands clasped firmly behind her back. Her mask was lit by the glowing shard of the Black Garnet which cracked deadly red lightning around her face, and her back was lit by the great RuneStone that drove emperors and princesses and sorceresses mad. That sickening red light filled the chamber. She stood on shaking legs and held her hands out again in the form that Shadow Weaver had taught her time and time again.

The older woman's eyes narrowed into slits as she looked at her. Eventually, with a sigh, she opened up her hands and more of the vile lightning arced between her fingers. In a voice calm and sweet she said, "Come now, Adora, you can do better than this. Feel the flow of magic."

Adora couldn't feel anything except the aching of her limbs. She gathered her *kiari* off the ground where it had fallen from spasming fingers and held it in front of her, as if a blade of wood could protect her from the destructive magicks of the world. Of Shadow Weaver. Perhaps this time it would.

Beneath her mask Shadow Weaver scowled. "Very well, Adora. Once again, feel the flow of energy, and you can redirect it into the blade to protect yourself… Try again."

For the eighth time that day, Adora collapsed to the ground in a writhing mass. Her muscles shrieked as the dark current ran through her and she couldn't stop the sob of pain that escaped her throat. Her *kiari* clattered to the ground and rolled to a stop at

the hem of Shadow Weaver's dress. She let out a long sigh and leaned down to pick up the fallen blade. She held it in one hand and examined the length of it while Adora whimpered once, twice more on the floor before slowly extending her hand out towards the weapon.

"You rely too much on such tools," the old witch said. "Just like Lonnie, you lack the discipline to realize it is a crutch and not true mastery. But even with such a crutch, you continue to insist on being a disappointment." Every word was laced with her characteristic venom. "I am aware the barbarian demands you keep this on you at all times or else you will fail to become a sword master as he intends. So," she dropped the weapon unceremoniously a few feet in front of Adora's outstretched hand, "you may keep it. A crutch for now."

Bleary eyed, Adora pulled herself forward despite the screaming pain she felt; she couldn't rise even if she wanted to. Her hand clutched the hilt and she felt a sense of calm wash over her again. It also felt wrong.

She tried to push herself up to her feet. She made it as far as her knees before her body violently twitched as the aftershocks ran through her again and she fell to the floor again, this time clutching the *kiari* as tightly as she could to her chest. She took several deep shuddering breaths in through her nose, out through her mouth, inhale, exhale. Life: as long as she was breathing, she could rise again. She blinked the pain from her eyes and rolled onto her front. Getting one hand under her, she pushed herself up again.

"Good, you continue to rise. Endurance will serve you well, provided you are willing to learn." Shadow Weaver held her hands crackling with potency out again. "So, do try to pay attention this time, Adora. Feel for the magical energy. You have a reserve in you, a strength, and yet you constantly refuse to acknowledge it."

The door to the chamber slid open and Adora could almost smell her (her sense of smell was always better than others). The

strange, cold smell underlined with charred flesh. Knight Lonnie watched her from the doorway. Her oldest friend, her squadmate. She had mastered these lessons while Adora struggled with the basics.

She finally rose to her feet, swaying and nearly unable to breathe. She was trying to clear the bright light from behind her eyes by blinking. She could see for a moment the flow of magic, the path the lightning would follow before it struck. She bit down on her bottom lip, tasting copper. She would be ready, she could see, she would not fail, she would not disappoint her, she would prove herself to both Shadow Weaver and Lonnie.

The lightning struck like a viper lunging from Shadow Weaver's palm right towards Adora. She went to counter with her blade, the *kiari* striking at the threatening spell.

She fell for the ninth time that day…

Primary Medical Facility

Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Twelve Days After Adora's Abduction

The bright lights of the infirmary glared down at her as she awoke. Bile rose in her throat as terror gripped her; she was back here, she hadn't been back in the infirmary proper in years. Shadow Weaver had called out a doctor to check her when she was injured, not bring her here where Vultak or Dr. Tempus could get ahold of her. ~~She remembered a kindly doctor who would wipe away her tears with a tail and answer her questions about what he was doing.~~

The door slid open and the same figure from her nightmares walked in. The slightly hunched form of Vultak, his wings folded against his back, his talons made a sickening *clack clack* against the metal ground. She tried to move only to find her arms were secured in place with thick cords. Straining against the restraints, she could only move a few inches.

He stalked closer, then placed one clawed hand on her chin, a single talon wiped under her nose, a few ruby droplets of blood. He grinned and brought the droplet up to eye level. "So, the witch finally returned you to me? No more hiding you away?" he chuckled. "Tut, tut. Do not struggle, little anomaly. It will only make this more painful for you."

She glared at him, trying to muster what courage she could. His grin was wicked and predatory. "Now, I think it's time to have a full examination at what Shadow Weaver has hidden away for so long." He reached onto a table just out of Adora's sight, pulling up with a syringe of something. She attempted to struggle against her restraints and achieved only tearing at her arms.

Vultak chuckled, and with a soft *clack* and a *tick*, a small recorder was placed on a table nearby. "Medical Research log and treatment of Subject 0289 'Cadet Adora'. See log 14-02 for previous record keeping. Subject is to receive both an examination as well as treatment for electrical damage inflicted by Commander Weaver in training."

Adora's breath caught in her throat. She was getting an examination. It had been a decade since Shadow Weaver let Vultak's claws near her, giving her treatment over to a… to a… *to a hybrid doctor from the wastes.* She was usually sedated so it took her a minute to remember*.*

Vultak was far crueler than that old hybrid; this would be painful. She could feel tears pricking her eyes. "Subject is of an unknown species and, whilst records are flimsy, based on previous documents, appears to be of a healthy weight and size though slightly below predicated growth, but well within anticipated

parameters.” He stalked around her form, his wings fluttering slightly. Cold eyes staring down at her as if she was just another corpse for him to examine.

“The subject is estimated to be sixteen years of age and still appears as an adolescent though reaching the end of maturity, as anticipated of a standard Etherian. It appears to have a healthy dental practice and hair is well kept and shorn to military standard. Remaining hair samples have been collected for examination as per Shadow Weaver’s request.” *Remaining hair samples? She had kept her hair military standard for years.*

“It has moderate scarring, though below average for a cadet of its age. Notably, lichtenberg scaring around the temples and more recently still fresh injuries from training exercise this morning, scaring on lower legs and arms is still present from log 14-02. Also of minor note, several minor punctures as if from a needle that have not fully healed occur in the ears and on the inner cartilage of the nasal. Approximate height is five foot ten inches and at estimation appears to be a healthy weight." He stops directly in her vision, holding up the syringe in one clawed hand and in the other a scalpel.

“Subject is to be given a light sedative to make it more conducive to treatment and examination as per standard protocols from experiments in log 14-01.” He grinned wickedly down at her, a glee entering the clinical tone of his voice. She felt a pinprick in her thigh as the syringe dug in. She wouldn’t cry out despite the clawing at her chest.

Vultak prowled to the back of the room, his voice becoming distant, and began to lay out a series of tools as she slowly felt the world receding around her. She tried to keep her focus on the figure of her nightmares. After a few minutes where she felt she was holding onto consciousness by a fingernail, he picked up a syringe. “Starting with a basic blood sample.”

A strong hand grabbed at her arm which felt like it was in shackles. She felt the needle enter her arm and had to bite on her

tongue not to scream. She couldn't stop her body from shaking. It couldn't have been more than a minute or so by the count of her breath but it felt like hours.

"Despite the sedative, the subject appears panicked. Perhaps a dosage increase is required, as much as it pains me to lose out on the delicious fear. Things must be done… properly." As he said the last word, he placed the vial full of blood down on the countertop and moved the scalpel from his left hand to his right. "Then again, perhaps not." His grin was malicious like a fox that had broken into the coop.

He reached down with the scalpel. She couldn't breath, couldn't even control her steady pace. She wouldn't scream, she wouldn't scream. The door to the room slammed open and Vultak's head swivelled around. Sickly green light poured in from the outside and Adora couldn't see who had opened the door. Her heart was pounding too fast to even really understand the conversation. She had to calm down.

"What do you think you're doing, Vultak?" came a woman's voice, soft in tone, not Shadow Weaver's. "This is absolutely not okay!" The voice carried some authority hard with conviction.

"The witch will not be pleased with this disruption," Vultak crooned out, his voice remarkably soft for his violent demeanour. "I am not pleased with this disruption, either. This is supposed to be a sterile environment and I have work to do."

"No, you don't," the voice countered. "I have come to get Adora and make sure she's safe. Unless you want Lord Hordak to hear about this, which I will tell him about. He'll be annoyed by you hurting a cadet for your own sick fascination." Whoever this voice was knew Hordak personally, and was willing to stand up to Vultak.

"You presume much, girl. I have—"

“Ah ba ba baa, I was told to come and collect her, and to make sure she was recovered for tomorrow, and, Vultak, whatever you are going to do to her won’t be recovered by tomorrow, will it?” the voice interrupted him again. His face turned to a scowl. He went to draw in a breath, the room's shadows seemed to twist in Adora’s mind.

There was a clicking sound, and the voice interrupted again. “I wouldn’t try it, General. Don’t want your precious lab to get all messy, do we?” Something pressed against the bindings against Adora's wrist. She looked down to see a pincer, and with a *snip,* her arm was free. Instantly, she was clawing at the other restraint to get it off. A second figure put a scaled fist on her own and undid the restraints.

In the seconds it took to free herself, the first figure had moved closer to Vultak. The tip of a huge stinger dripping with venom was held an inch above Vultak's left eye, steady as a boulder in a breeze. Force Captain Scorpia looked like a knight in shining carapace to Adora. Scorpia placed one of her pincers on Adora’s shoulder to steady her, the other figure moving around to help her to her feet. Scorpia gave one last look to Vultak “Come on, Adora, let's get you back to your bunk.”

Adora’s feet felt like leaden weights, her body moving so sluggishly like she had run round the Fright Zone three dozen times and did so while carrying a bag of steel ingots on her back. Still, she was so grateful she could have kissed Scorpia then. She wouldn’t—that would be weird—but she could have. On the other side of her one arm slung under her shoulder was Rogelio, his bulk allowing him to support her weight.

With his help, she moved around the table as Vultak glared at them both. She was suddenly compelled by an overwhelming urge, and her unconscious brain was moving her arms before she could acknowledge what she was doing.

She reached up to the recorder sitting so precariously close to the edge of the table and, with a gentle *thwack,* knocked it onto

the floor. Vultak lunged to grab it but his spidery fingers only closed around air as it collided to the ground with a *crunch* and broke apart. She smiled at that little vengeance. Scorpia laughed as well, and as Vultak rose with his wings expanding, she took Adora under the other arm, and the three of them rushed out of the room. Adora went limp as she was carried, the sedatives getting to her and she curled up in Scorpia's strong arms. Rogelio moved to one side as an honour guard. Without even thinking and half asleep, Adora began to hum at the back of her throat. Scorpia almost thought it sounded like purring.

The Black Garnet Chamber

Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Thirteen Days After Adora's Abduction

The doorway to the chamber stood before Lonnie. On the other side was the most terrifying monster in the Fright Zone, the woman who had raised her, the woman who had clearly tried at least once to get her killed in the name of growing stronger. Lonnie could admit that she was terrified of her; it was the sane position. Shadow Weaver commanded the Horde below only Hordak and was as cruel and vindictive as they came all behind a veneer of calm control. But she needed answers and only Shadow Weaver could give them.

She remembered a series of lessons with Isolde. Her old mentor was a waif of a woman, a deer hybrid from near Mystacor, and she had explained to her once: *"Fear is just like any other emotion: one must feel it, accept that it is part of you, and act anyway. It is not wrong to feel fear as even the greatest warrior does. It is wrong to let it control you."* Her teacher had explained it all while they drilled different forms. The two had run through

the forms with her mentor correcting them as she went. This was years ago, when Lonnie was barely a teenager, a few years before the betrayal.

"What are you afraid of, Teacher?" she had asked then, her eyes closed as she attempted to maintain a spell to enhance her senses without breaking the kata she was running through: a repeated form which required very precise pivots and blocks. Isolde took a moment to respond. She was tempted to crack an eye and look at her but that would break her form.

After a minute of silence, her teacher had responded with a voice as soft as the grave. "That I will never see Mystacor again." She stepped forward and placed one hand on Lonnie's back and another on her shoulder, twisting both a single degree. "Near perfect; you lost focus at the end. Run through it again."

Her teacher's fears had been realized, but how could they not in the halls of horrors that was the Fright Zone? It was in the name. The Horde embraced fear; it was a weapon they had against the Princesses and principalities, a weapon that they had grown and cultivated well in the garden of Shadow Weaver's malice and Hordak's twisted science.

But, even until the end, she didn't let her fear control her. She had guided and taught Lonnie as a kinder teacher than any before or since. She had waited for the ideal moment to escape; it would have worked had Lonnie not been present. Lonnie would not let her fear control her.

She entered the chamber. The inside was lit by the dark ruby lighting of the Black Garnet and, at the center of the chamber, stood Shadow Weaver, a report in one hand and a glass filled with some sloshing crimson liquid inside it in the other. She looked up with surprise on the strangely expressive mask that she wore evident for a moment before the normal calm settled over her.

"Knight Champion, to what do I owe the pleasure?" She placed the report down onto a small desk folded out from the wall, and

turned glass still in hand. Her voice still affects a calm and almost motherly tone. "If this is about Cadet Adora, I can only answer a few of your questions but you may ask them."

"What is she doing back here? What is she doing with my prisoner? And, most importantly, what was she doing in my private quarters?" she rattled of the questions. A hundred more burned on her tongue, but those three seemed most pressing. She feared she knew the answer to at least one of them.

"Adora has long been a project for me; from the moment I found her, she was to be my inheritor. Her temporary loss to that creature from Subtheria was always going to be that: temporary. I have successfully retrieved her and we can resume her training." Lonnie recoiled as if slapped. "As for your prisoner, he is a trained warrior and while it appears that she has not been lax in her training in Subtheria, she needs someone to push her further. Your prisoner is an adequate warrior to do so."

Lonnie rolled her shoulders. It was exactly as she thought: Adora—perfect, beloved Adora always getting the best treatment—had been brought back to replace her, a more manipulatable pawn for Shadow Weaver's twisted game. She took a calming breath, no point getting angry, not yet.

"And my final question: I have a suspicion but how did she find her way to my quarters? How did she know the codes to get in? I assume it's to do with the decade she's missing from that big forehead of hers?" Trying to break a joke to keep the venom out of her voice barely worked, and she knew Shadow Weaver could sense her rising temper. After all, she cultivated that temper as much as she cultivated fear.

"Observant Lonnie, you always were. A quality I do think you should focus on. Yes, I had to make a great many… alterations to poor Adora's memories to give her a life in the Fright Zone. Some of her memories are created wholesale and some of which I may have had to source from a reliable source." She shrugged, as if

she wasn't admitting to stealing Lonnie's memories, to fucking with Adora's head. All to play her sick game.

She continued. "Some are from soldiers close to death who willingly gave their memories over in exchange for being kept away from Dr. Tempus and Vultak in their final hours. Others, I had to acquire from a *closer* source."

Lonnie hummed along gently; a habit Shadow Weaver had never managed to break, despite repeated efforts. The old witch didn't comment on it, but she did move closer to Lonnie. With her free hand, she placed it upon her shoulder. It took every ounce of restraint not to tense under the touch.

"You and your squad have always been *close* to me and to each other. I chose you all. I saw your talent all those years ago, Lonnie. Adora was always going to be my inheritor but you could do so much and do not think that, in the years she has been gone, I have ignored your progress. You have done so much in such little time—a true prodigy; you would have been wasted anywhere else."

She moved the hand from her shoulder to cup Lonnie's cheek and, without thinking and desperate to prove herself, she leaned in to the touch. She knew it was the wrong move, but her traitorous body wouldn't obey her.

"Your memories and the memories of your squad will only make her stronger, but not as strong as you, who have actually lived them. I want you to remember that you have endured hardship, Knight Lonnie, and lived. But you must always keep a careful watch for danger. It can come from any corner." She removed her hand, and Lonnie was adept enough to recognise the threat. She was always coy like this, making her plays from the shadows. The warning was either real and given to keep her sharp, or fictitious and was designed to make her paranoid. She knew this, and still, and still. She couldn't ignore a warning from Shadow Weaver.

"I will have other questions." She tried to steady her voice; it wavered only slightly. "And I don't want anything else pulled from my head!" The anger was coming back to her now.

"Of course," Shadow Weaver said far too quickly for Lonnie's liking. "Before you go, Lonnie, I have a few questions for you." That was never a good sign. She nodded once. *Get this over with quickly, and get back to the boys so you can explain and vent. Maybe half an hour of sparing would clear my head.* Shadow Weaver placed the glass down on the table; half of the contents had been drained away though Lonnie never saw her drink any of it.

"Adora was carrying this upon her recovery. She took great pains to not let it go. It took *convincing* to separate her from it, and my knowledge on matters martial is… rudimentary at best. I have separated it from the rest of her possessions which I have kept secured away ready for disposal. You are welcome to peruse them, if you wish. The clothing was… revealing, but could you explain the importance of this?" She reached into her robe and withdrew a length of worked wood, a beautiful wooden blade of a strange red wood with swirling patterns. It was brimming with the strange golden magic that suffused Adora, and which she could not access.

She reached out a hand, and Shadow Weaver placed the blade into her grip. The weight was perfect, balanced exactly right. It was a few centimeters too long for her to use it in her fighting style without some adaptation but, for a practitioner of *kirith,* it was perfectly made.

"It's a *kiari*—the practice blade of a warrior of *kirith*. A dead martial art, or it's supposed to be. But the prisoner carried one as well, as I am sure you know." Shadow Weaver inclined her head at that. "So, unless he found it, and I very much doubt it, he's a practitioner of *kirith.* I don't know why Adora would have one if she's been running around Subtheria." She remembered that warrior who had slaughtered the Horde soldiers on that night over a decade ago. If he was a *khir'saya,* that would explain how he

was so effective. She couldn't remember on that grainy footage if he carried a *kiari* but it would explain so much. "Those who practice *kirith* must keep this blade on them at all times. It's a religious thing, I think. Adora would no more be parted from this blade than her arm." *Or her memories.* "If she is trained in *kirith* then she is far more dangerous than I would have given her credit for."

Shadow Weaver nodded, and took the blade back from her. "Perhaps it is best that you observe her next true training session with the prisoner when you return." Lonnie nodded, she was going off to oversee the initial construction project for the new fortress for the next few days. A few days out of the worst of the choking smog of the Fright Zone and in the cool desert air would be good to clear her head. "Lonnie," Shadow Weaver continued, "perhaps it is best if Kyle and Rogelio went along with you for your observations." She paused at that. Lonnie felt her heart catch in her throat.

"Why? What has Kyle done now?" she tried to snark, but fear was now gripping her. She tried to do as instructed to feel the fear and not let it control her. "Is it Octavia again?"

"Oh, it's not Kyle this time, Rogelio has made an enemy even I would struggle to protect him from. If you wish to keep them both safe, I would suggest a long trip out of the Fright Zone for a few days." The woman collected her glass. "You are dismissed, Knight Leor."

Lonnie fled from the room, rushing to her quarters and getting Kyle on the comms. She needed a plan. Something long term, something that would give her an edge over Shadow Weaver and her twisted mind games and to protect Rogelio from whatever mistake he had made…

The Tomb

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Thirteen Days After Adora's Abduction

Again Adora awoke in an unfamiliar place, darkness pressed in around her. She could feel the cold stone under her bare feet and pressed against her back. She had been led here on Shadow Weaver's instruction. To this *tomb*. She shuddered, and as she opened her eyes she couldn't see anything—the room was pure darkness.

Her breath caught in her throat as she scrambled up to her feet. There had to be a way out of here. She barely made it three paces before she collided with the opposite wall. She held out her arms and could only just stretch between the two—this room was tiny and she was trapped in it. There may be just enough room for her to lie down and curl up.

She did just that, lying down curled up trying to hold herself as still as possible as she shook with terror. *How long would she be down here?* She tried to take a calming breath, but it came out as choked sob. *Had she been down here before?* She must have been. But why couldn't she remember anything except the fear? She curled up even tighter on herself. ~~*If she had a tail, she would be pulling on it in anxiety.*~~ She let the tears flow. She couldn't stop them even if she tried.

She had no idea how long she just lay there sobbing—it could have been minutes or hours, she certainly felt exhausted enough. She clambered to her feet. Running a hand around the length of the room, there was no clear exit but that didn't mean there wasn't one on the floor or roof. She couldn't see anything but running her hands along the floor showed the same smooth stone, and the roof was way above her head. She was well and truly trapped. Alone, in the dark. She almost bit her tongue off with her trembling fear.

Shadow Weaver had said that even with all her training, she had never been able to find the source of her power. She knew it was there, she had saved Kyle with it when he was attacked, but she could never truly access it again, locked away behind… behind what? Shadow Weaver had never explained, simply demanding she focus harder, eliminate distractions. She had done that, been separated from the squad for years, and only ever worked to the bone to discover her powers.

Shadow Weaver knew her fear of the dark, had known about it since she was a baby and now was exploiting it to try and get her to focus more. She couldn't even breathe down here. It was agony to open her eyes so she kept them squeezed shut and tried, tried desperately to reach for her powers.

It was there, she could feel it: a glow, a warmth beneath her skin. Yet, every time she went to grasp for it, it slipped between her fingers like hot sand. She couldn't use it like this. She would try to grasp it, a means of escape. She knew if she just held on for a few minutes, a few seconds, she could escape this place and yet the power denied her each time. She kept trying, and on each failure, she would fall to her knees and break slightly more. She had to get out of here. She couldn't die down here in the dark, Shadow Weaver wouldn't leave her down here, would she?

Again and again she tried to grasp for the golden light that was supposed to be hers, and it never responded, forcing her back to this tomb each time. It must have been hours; she was growing hungry and thirsty and couldn't even keep her eyes open. She had not felt this bone-weary exhaustion in years, not even after hours of training with Duncan.

Duncan, that strange warrior, an assassin sent to kill Lord Hordak, yet he taught her with honour and with kindness how to face her fears. To find something to hold onto, a worthy cause and to stand against your fears anyway. She thought of his teaching, even here in the dark she could feel it, dropped on the floor after her. Her *kiari* had been left unceremoniously on the

floor. Duncan had given it to her in their first lesson together. She clutched it tightly in her hands.

He had called her a natural with the blade and asked who her teacher was. She couldn't answer. She couldn't remember beyond Cobalt and a few of the Horde instructors, but she had never held a sword before that day. Duncan didn't believe it. "No one is that good naturally," he had said of her.

She bowed her head down, placing her forehead against the pommel. Where had her skills come from? She could focus on that rather than the dark. Or at least she could try—it was all encompassing, and her fear grew with it. Every minute down here was agony, worse even than being up with Vultak.

She had thanked Rogelio as they had left—she had not been there for her squad in years, and they were not there for her but he came when she was in need—and she had thanked Scorpia who owed her nothing. But even that fear was manageable in comparison to the terror the dark held.

She held one deep breath. It had been hours, it may even be the next day, she couldn't know. Time seemed to blur past her, one day bleeding into another. Perhaps faulty memory was just a thing that happened to whatever her people are. She would have to hope that they would come through for her again, that someone would come for her.

The fear was there, but she had allies here. Shadow Weaver may be testing her but even she wouldn't test her to destruction. Lonnie may be all high and mighty with her new authority and skill but they had helped each other through the darkest moments. Rogelio had grunted that they would protect each other. He wouldn't abandon her.

That was what you did in the Horde; each soldier of a squad looked out for others from their own squad. It's who you fought for, or so the others had said, but she had always been kept

separated except in matters of training and rarely when she absolutely needed it.

She was close to all her squad. They had fought and bled together. They would not abandon her down here in the dark, even if Shadow Weaver demanded it of them. Lonnie held her new position's strength and that meant bucking Shadow Weaver's power on occasion. She would gloat about it and hold it over her likely forever, but she would come save her.

She knelt there in the pitch black, and hoped against all reason that someone would come for her. The danger would surround her, but it would not bring her down. As she tried to kindle that flame of hope in her chest, she found herself muttering something. The words were foreign to her but she knew their meaning. She knew the cadence and the rhythm that they were spoken to, a prayer. *Why did she know a prayer? The Horde didn't have prayers!*

The words kept coming unbidden, and despite not knowing the meaning, she knew beyond doubt that it was calming, a prayer against the shadows that gathered around her. A prayer of a warrior. She closed her eyes as she recited it, each line of verse coming to her without hesitation and only when she thought to look in her own mind to think of why she knew this did she stumble. The verse spoke of gathering your own strength, to stand united against darkness. She stood alone here, but she had people she could rely on. She let that verse act as the kindling, the burning hope within her, and as the words came to a close, she opened her eyes. The room was not pitch black, it was lit however faintly by her skin, which glowed with a golden light.

She would be strong and she would be brave and the darkness would not defeat her, no matter how much she feared it.

Chapter End Notes

This will likely be our last post for a little while whilst we recover from burnout. Please do check out our other fics.

Alternately if you want to chat please come chat on the Defiance Discord

Chapter 4: Sewing Friendship

Chapter Summary

Adora tries her hand at sewing not knowing why she knows this skill.

Chapter Notes

- Content Warning:

The Barracks

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Month After Adora's Abduction

Adora shivered despite the heat of the room—the Fright Zone was always hot, too many bodies stuffed into a large metal box filled with electrical equipment. Her arms were wrapped tightly around herself as if she could simply hold herself tightly enough that the pain and fear would be squeezed out of her.

The dark of the chamber was held back only by a tiny night light, something Kyle had scrounged together as a gift for her, made out of an old flashlight with a specialized bulb designed for work in Subtheria, and a battery pack that could sustain itself almost indefinitely. She had thanked him profusely for the gift; she felt the need to give him something in return. She would work that out soon; she was good with her hands, and knew how to work a small collection of tools which she kept in her tiny closet alongside what few meagre possessions she had collected over her time in the Horde.

The lights would come on in a few hours but, as tradition in the Horde, more than a handful of people were up already, some going to extra training, some running errands, some doing favours for others. Often these early people were sneaking in extra water rations against regulation. Adora had longed to do that—she was always thirsty, but she had found a better way.

Horde clothing was issued in bulk around Founding Day and was mainly one size fits all but everyone ended up needing either repairs or to make customizations—a small act of personal rebellion that was often overlooked by senior command provided it didn't remove Horde's insignia or damage rank badges. For years, she had done only basic maintenance on her uniform with no modifications. But now, far away from her original barracks and training to become a blademaster under a strange teacher, she felt the need to make some changes to her clothes.

So it was that she had done a nighttime raid into the quartermaster's office—a tradition for Cadets who needed something that would be declined as not necessary—and acquired a needle, thread, cloth, even a pair of fabric scissors all without getting caught (the few other cadets she noticed didn't even seem to spot her).

After she had returned, she had set about making minor alterations to the uniform. Bringing the hemline up to expose some of her midriff, and cutting the sleeves slightly down to show off her wrists and allow them to move more, all the adjustments she made just felt natural. The movement of needle and thread felt natural, as if she had been doing it for years.

It took multiple nights of waking up early to adjust all her clothes to better fit herself. Duncan had approved, and Shadow Weaver had narrowed her eyes but said nothing, a taciturn approval, well at least not a dismissal with punishment.

Soon others came to her. Rogelio was first, his uniform torn and made of difficult to work material. He had spotted her work and offered to trade her his extra water rations for help repairing

his uniform. After that, word spread: Shadow Weaver's hidden protege was back and worked textiles as well as a blade. She found it soothing, and the traded favours and added water rations soothed her aching throat.

And so every day, two hours before lights on, she got up, made the bed, did her stretches, and then set to work gently cutting and sewing whatever uniform had been presented to her with whatever little modification she needed to make in exchange for ration bar;, extra battery cells; or, most precious of all, water rations.

Her current project was for a scout crew. The entire crew had survived a tour in Subtheria and were going back down there, and to help identify themselves, they had a small patch they wanted sewn onto the breast of all their uniforms. It was a small cloth thing cut to look like a goblin's blade. The squad were desperate to get it done and were willing to trade something rarer than water: contraband brought back from Subtheria.

At first, her instinct was to report them but when their leader —a large beastfolk man—showed her a beautiful flower, they looked at her and said, "You smoke it. Crush up the petals with the butt of your knife or the tip of your staff and roll it into a thin sheet of paper, and light one end on fire. Inhale it and it will get you to relax. Just don't do it with a superior officer around." She should have reported them but something about that flower and the idea of getting to relax made her agree.

So, she had that flower tucked away in a small glass vial she had pilfered from medical last time she had been sent there. She would need it, eventually. Every time she was left in the dark of the tomb she came out shaking with terror, unable to calm herself, and each time she had needed something to calm her nerves beyond a mantra she didn't understand and the weight of the *kiari* in her hands. Maybe once, if she couldn't get calm, she would find a place to hide, and smoke the flower to see what it would do.

The work was calming, soothing almost. It was simple and clean and she was finished with under half an hour to spare. She would make the delivery tonight before heading to bed and get the rest of the flower that was promised to her alongside a few bottles of water. She finished up her morning routine as the main lights flickered to life, and she gently flicked the switch on the night light she kept beside her bed at all times.

Today was another good day. She would be meeting up with her *Ahran* and training through the forms. She was good. It felt good to be practicing with the blade again. She made her way to the *tenemos*. Scorpia was busy today and tomorrow—something involving Lord Hordak—so she was left to fend for herself.

As she arrived, she heard the clash of metal on wood, so she hurried her step. Duncan was an expert fighter—no one should be able to overcome him in his *tenemos,* who would dare even try. She shouldered open the door to see Duncan deftly dodging and parrying blows from a foe who was equally as agile, weaving between his strikes. Twin blades flashing out against her *Ahran's* own single, hefty wooden cudgel. She watched transfixed. It took her a moment to recognise the other figure as Lonnie, flowing like water from strike to strike. Dodging and weaving with unnatural grace. She was testing Duncan and pushing herself. Their weapons met again with a solid crash and Adora realized that Lonnie was better than her. A better swordswoman despite Duncan's praises.

The two broke apart and both were panting, sweat beading on their brows. She could see the practice blades had left a nasty welt on Duncan's thigh and his cudgel had struck Lonnie's shoulder, leaving a deep purple bruise. Lonnie straightened, rolling her shoulders. Duncan turned to face Adora and she fell into the bow she was taught to show respect to her *Ahran.*

Lonnie snorted. "Eyes up, Adora." Adora glanced up to see Duncan glaring at Lonnie who was leaning back against a wall massaging her shoulder with one hand and holding a bottle of water in the other.

Duncan approached a far wall, switching the cudgel he kept there for his *kiari* and turned back to the room. "Knight Leor has asked to be your sparring partner for today." His voice was stone: impossible to read. She had heard the story, that Lonnie had been there on the day of the assassination attempt, that she had killed her own mentor, the woman who lived in this very room, that day and that Lord Hordak and Shadow Weaver had captured and restrained Duncan. She also knew that Lonnie came down to spar with him often, since her old mentor was dead. Lonnie had chosen to become a sorceress, earning Shadow Weavers favour and mastering the blade as well. After Lonnie chose to become a sorceress, Adora had been pushed further aside.

Adora remembered being left alone in favour of the more magically adept Lonnie, that she had fallen somewhat out of favour and became a fascinating piece of Shadow Weaver's puzzle, a trophy, training to be a soldier. Now that Lonnie was trained, and was a master of both magical arts and the sword, she had once again been taken back into the spotlight.

Lonnie shrugged off of the wall, dropping her blades onto a heavy cloak resting on the bench in the room. She collected two practice blades, shorter in length than Adora's *kiari*. She stretched, testing the weight of the practice swords and adjusting while Adora fell into a combat stance across from her. Lonnie's grin was vicious. There was something in her eyes that Adora couldn't identify. A look that conveyed a message of… disgust? Hatred? Anger? It was impossible to tell.

"Begin!" Duncan barked the order and Lonnie lunged, not in the patient style of *kirith* but something else entirely. Something achingly familiar. Lightning quick, she was up against Adora, moving to try and disarm her. Adora parried the first three rapid strikes of her violent flurry. The fourth strike before she could counter went against her thigh, a shallow blow that only stung. Adora struck out, seeing an opening that wasn't actually there as Lonnie danced back.

It was the only way to describe it: a dance. It was so at odds with the brutish girl she remembered from her childhood who would fist fight a lizardfolk for daring to bully Rogelio for being too small and something in the dance hurt to watch, like it was familiar even though she was so certain she had never watched Lonnie fight before today.

Lonnie's first strike would have been to kill. In a real fight, Adora may have suffered a severe gash on the leg and been hampered for the rest of the fight, probably leading to her death. In this sparring match, it would just leave a bruise. She slowed after that, testing the limits of Adora's skill. Certainly Adora could hold her own.

Adora's shock at seeing Lonnie's skill faded as she moved to counter and swing herself. They broke apart and Lonnie rolled her shoulders again, looking annoyed she bounced on the balls of her feet, the faint *clink clink* of two small black gemstones tied into her braided hair as they bounced against each other.

"You're better than I thought you would be." Lonnie was looking past her, at the far wall. Adora kept her focus fixed on the woman in front of her, every bit the deadly warrior the propaganda made her out to be. "I thought you would only get the most basic of training before Shadow Weaver snatched you back up." She shook her head and stepped forwards, twirling each blade between her fingers—a deft manoeuvre but one born of anxiety rather than trying to intimidate. She could still read her; they grew up together, trained for years together. This aggression was new, but the anxiety was the same.

She lunged and Adora felt the rhythm that Lonnie was moving to. She moved with the grace she needed too stay alive. It's clear in a fair fight Lonnie would win more than half the time. Adora could score blows against her, but she wasn't as good as the Knight of the Fright Zone. Is this what Shadow Weaver saw in her? And this was without using her sorceress powers?

Lonnie could conjure arcane sigils and summon fire and frost. Everyone knew that, so this wasn't the limit of her skill. Adora was suddenly terrified, not just of her, a friend who had chosen willingly to walk down the path of madness and seemed only to balance it on the razor's edge of martial skill, but also of Shadow Weaver. Is this why she got pushed so heavily aside, someone actually willing to embrace that madness? Something beyond a champion. Made out of the girl who hugged her in the dark when she was scared.

Five rounds they went, and Adora only won in the final round, striking a blow against the sternum. Lonnie grunted and her eyes seemed to fill with flecks of black as the two gems set into her hair crackled, the tips of her fingers glowing with arcane light around the hilts of the blade, when Duncan shouted, "Match to Adora!"

Lonnie calmed, taking a settling breath, the magic winking out of existence in the heartbeat they took to appear. She nodded to Duncan and held out a hand to Adora.

"Finally nice to have my sparring partner back," she laughed, the anger gone from her voice. Adora sheathed her blade and saluted Lonnie, before bowing deeply to Duncan. "No need to be so formal, Adora. What, not got that stick removed yet?" she laughed again and even Duncan smirked slightly. Adora glared at both of them.

"Good to be back. Can't believe I missed out on all this training. You got way better than me, way too quickly." She smiled at her and, for a few moments, it was like the bot sims all over again, the trio gently ribbing her and her as their stern leader. "But I'll catch up. Then it'll be us two against the whole damn world." She laughed at that. Something about the two of them felt right, and wrong like a piece was missing. Lonnie threw an arm around her shoulders before she could think anymore on it. Laughing alongside her, making jokes about Kyle and Rogelio, and through it all Adora couldn't help but notice that laughter never quite reached Lonnie's eyes.

Outside the Tomb

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two Months After Adora's Abduction

It had been worse than the other times she had been left down there; longer, too. The first time had been ten hours, the time after twelve, this time Shadow Weaver had left her in the dark of the tomb for nearly eighteen hours. Scorpia had pulled her out on shaking feet and let her collapse down. Her muscles were cramped, she was thirsty—she was always thirsty now—and she was tired, her throat raw from screaming and still the magic eluded her. A month of having whole days lost to the darkness and she could only weep for her failures.

She struggled back to the light and lay there, taking shuddering breaths, slowly stretching her hand out and flexing the stiffness out of her fingers from gripping her *kiari* so tightly. Scorpia allowed her to gather her strength at her own pace—the Force Captain was far kinder than anyone else in the Horde to her except for Duncan. She spent maybe ten minutes lying on the ground before rising to her feet. Scorpia was gentle with her pincers guiding her back to the Champions' barracks.

She clambered up into her bunk above Scorpia's and laid there for a moment until she heard a chuckling voice. Normally, Scorpia's glare kept the others from acting out or even joking about Adora when she was in this position, and certainly Scorpia was trying, too, now—Adora could see that. But it did nothing to dissuade Lonnie who walked over to the bunk and leaned against the frame.

“You look like you’re doing great, Adora.” Her voice dripped with sarcasm. “Go another round with Shadow Weaver? I knew something was up when the assassin kept getting a distracted look. Not enough for me to beat him but enough that I made him bruise.” She was smug; Lonnie was always smug, and brave. Stupidly brave. Adora remembered that, on her first day here, Lonnie had stood up to Shadow Weaver, and demanded things from her. She had confided in her once how afraid she had been, laying one ~~claw~~ hand on her arm.

Adora could do nothing but groan. Her anxiety over the tomb was still gripping her like a vice, the fear not leaving her body and her aching muscles. A deep, indescribable terror of knowing that she was no closer to her power and thus only another week away from going back down into the dark again. She wanted to throw up, to just lay here and hold herself.

Lonnie’s voice once again broke the thoughts “Shit, Adora…” A hand pressed onto her arm and suddenly another voice was shouting.

“Don’t touch her!” It was Scorpia’s. She was protective of her. But Lonnie was safe, she thought. She looked over to see Scorpia had one claw on Lonnie’s outstretched arm, and the other was frozen in a layer of rimmed frost an inch from Lonnie’s throat. Her tail was blocked by the flat of the curved, metal blade Lonnie had taken to carrying. Scorpia met her eye, and she shook her head and a moment later Scorpia had retreated back to the small desk she had set up near the bunk.

“Awfully protective big gal you’ve got there.” Lonnie said, her cheeks flushed slightly. When Adora didn’t respond, she hopped up to sit at the foot of the bunk, as smooth as they used to do when they were children, and just sat there with her in silence. Adora buried her face in the pillow to hide any tears. Lonnie always said she wouldn’t judge her for them but she wasn’t the same anymore. She was a knight, an uncompromising warrior, not a little girl who also cried for her mama and mom.

She sat there for fifteen or twenty minutes. Just waiting with her. Adora's breathing slowly shallowed out and the last thing she recalled before slipping into a deep, bone-weary sleep was Lonnie reaching over and turning on her night light before hopping off the bed.

The Barracks

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two Months After Adora's Abduction

It was a few days after that strange interaction before Lonnie saw Adora again, this time it was at her normal sparring with the assassin. She could admit, whatever the mongrel king had taught her seemed to have stuck; she was damn good with a blade. Clearly, her time away had given her some skills. She still lacked access to her magic, and despite Weaver's best efforts, they seemed no closer to manifesting. Lonnie could feel it as well. Just below the surface of her skin, as if she was a foundry furnace that could burn you from a dozen feet away and yet she couldn't touch it herself.

The workout against her was good though, leaving her sweating and slightly bruised. She was improving at a rate equal to Adora, finally having opponents focused on skill over brute strength let her put her reflexes to the test. She still would not use magic in the training arena. Her old mistress would demand in training to meet your foes with their skills, not with your own. She could continue to cast in the bot sims to keep her practice up, but here she didn't want to hurt either of them. Not really.

With a twist of her head, Adora's new *kiari* went whistling past her ear, close enough to cause her braids to twist and *clink*

against each other. She smirked at her, and slammed the flat of her blade into her slightly exposed guard, right into her forearm. In a normal fight against an armoured foe, it would do no more than push their arm away and leave their flank exposed but it was enough breathing room to start acting in the way she wanted again.

She laughed. Fighting like this was glorious, freeing almost, like being back in the good old days. Adora must have thought so, too, for, as she staggered away, she came up chuckling slightly with her weird snorting laugh that had not changed, and her eyes…

Fire and Ash, her eyes were glowing an unnatural electric blue. Her hair as well began to shift, as if carried by a strange breeze in the deadly silent room. Duncan shifted from his position against the wall, his own eyes shooting wide open. She was so shocked that she didn't have time to parry the return blow from Adora which sent her sprawling to the ground. Adora stood over her panting, her skin glowing faintly golden and laughed at her victory like clean rain over the fright zone.

Lonnie blinked up at her, and the light was gone, as if it was never there. Pushing herself up to her elbows, she could only stare.

It was Duncan that broke the silence with a "My Lady, Adora… What you just did… It's a power I have never seen before." Adora smiled over at him, looking slightly like she had something to drink.

"I just felt…" she went to say, when the whole room darkened. Shadows clinging to the walls broke away as their one true master entered. Shadow Weaver floated into the training hall. Lonnie could read her better than most and she could tell that the woman was smirking. Leaving the practice swords where they lay, Lonnie got to her feet and gripped the hilts of her true blades.

Adora had access to celestial magic, the kind spoken about by more religious folks out in the world. She had a damn near infinite well of the stuff, and she couldn't touch it except while fighting? That couldn't be good. Shadow Weaver must have felt that sudden surge of power and come running. She tried to listen in.

"...clearly this focus must be trained into you. I think another few hours will suffice. Focus on what you felt in this… conflict and try to conjure it at will." Her hand gripped around Adora's wrist as she dragged her away. Duncan went to move after her as his chains suddenly constricted around his throat. Lonnie looked at him, and then sighed. She gestured in Horde Battle Sign, *Stay, I will defend.* And strode off after Shadow Weaver.

It took her a few minutes to gather her belongings and catch up to her mentor. She knew that she had a place set aside for Adora to 'learn focus' which left Adora terrified and shaking but watching Adora go from jubilation from knocking her flat on her ass to outright terror and trembling in fear in a single moment was enough to cause even Lonnie concern. So what Adora faced, she wouldn't face it alone. Adora had abandoned her once before, but she was still her squad.

Following the path of Shadow Weaver, she eventually reached this 'Room of Contemplation' as Shadow Weaver had called it to her, and what her old mentor had said existed in Mystacor. Only to find Shadow Weaver standing alone in a plain looking room of old Scorpioni design, the floor behind her sealing over with the crackling energy of the Black Garnet turned the stone to a liquid and back again. A potent spell, one that might take Lonnie days to calculate on how to perform. From within the rapidly sealing hole she could hear muffled sobbing. Shadow Weaver was placing Adora in a pitch black cell, smaller than the prison block cells?!

"Knight Captain, what are you doing here?" Shadow Weaver turned, sounding genuinely surprised in her condescending way. Her hand twisting as it conjured the last of the runes needed to finish the spell trapping Adora in the dark.

“I came to keep an eye on Adora since you interrupted our training match.” She was feeling bold today. Whatever Adora could do had rattled Shadow Weaver enough that she panicked at the first sign of Adora gaining control not on her terms. Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes down at Lonnie who stared back with her usual cocky defiance.

“The cadet and her training are of no concern to you, Lonnie. Return to your duties.” It was as clear a dismissal as there could be. Lonnie didn’t move an inch. After a few seconds the older woman snarled, “Did you not hear me?!”

“Oh, I heard you loud and clear. But my duties today consist of training Adora, since you are so desperate to have a second Knight under your thumb and so minor logistics I can do from right here.” She reached into her satchel and pulled out the small tablet that Kyle had given her. Tapping the edge of it against the side of her head, she continued, “And this room seems nice and cool, not much technology, stone floor. Isolated. I think I’ll work in here for today.”

Shadow Weaver glared at her, and she just hummed a small, tuneless noise, waiting patiently. After a few moments, Shadow Weaver sighed. “It is good that you are… protective of her. Very well. I will return in eleven hours. I will not mind if you wait here by yourself for the duration, but do not attempt to open the tomb or there will be consequences.” And, with that, the woman drifted past her.

She waited thirty seconds for the woman to be gone before letting her body shiver and her humming to intensify. Eventually, she sank to the floor and sat there, working through her various spells that Shadow Weaver had called "inconsequential to your goals” but Isolde had referred to as "fundamental and useful for any sorcerer worth a damn.” Eventually, she recalled the trick to the simple spell.

Reaching out past the stone, she whispered a message following the gesture in Horde Sign. Within, Adora should hear the

whisper and know she was not alone. She couldn't respond, not without having her own practice with this spell, but, every few minutes, she would send a word down to Adora, just a short "I'm here" and then settle back to her work, sorting out logistics for fortress building, contacting masons and metal workers, and now trying to figure out how to turn stone to liquid using her shards of the Black Garnet. While she wouldn't dare try it now, who knew when that kind of spell would be useful.

The day passed agonisingly slowly. She set to work on a normal kata, modified to fit the small size of the room, but at every interval, she sent a word of encouragement down into the dark. She sent a message to Kyle, Rogelio, and Scorpia. She practiced subtle, small spells, reminding herself of all the minor ones she had accumulated over the years. Eventually, Rogelio arrived with several ration bars (grey) and five full bottles of water. She downed one and saved the rest—one more for the rest of the day and the other three for Adora. She placed them carefully within her bag so that Weaver wouldn't notice upon her return.

She counted the minutes, which became hours, all while doing her work and being patient like a pool of water. At the twelfth hour to the minute, Shadow Weaver appeared in the doorway. The witch floated into the room and, with a gesture, the stone began to shift, her glare never leaving Lonnie's face.

With a gesture, Lonnie dropped a thick rope down into the dark which went taught a minute later as Adora began her climb. As Adora reached the surface, Shadow Weaver spoke without looking away from Lonnie. "Ah, Adora. I hope your time down in the dark was… enlightening. Perhaps you have learned to focus your magic?" Adora just shivered on the floor.

"I'll return her to the barracks and check her over. Ma'am, she'll be no good for you at the moment." Lonnie tried to inject some professionalism that had been beaten into her as a child into her voice. Shadow Weaver kept her gaze fixed on her before nodding once.

"Very well, Knight Lonnie. I expect her to resume her normal lessons. Do try to make sure she focuses properly." The compulsion to snarl at Weaver was all consuming but she forced it down like so much bile.

"Of course, Shadow Weaver."

She gathered Adora up under one arm. Adora tried to push her off but Lonnie grabbed her forcefully and said, "No, I'm helping or I'm knocking you out and carrying you." So, Adora relented and accepted the support from her as they walked back to the barracks. A few times, people would stare at her, at Adora showing some weakness. But Lonnie was the Knight of the Fright Zone and one glare back at them said *Back off or I boil your blood* and all of the soldiers averted their gaze.

It took them a few minutes to reach their bunk. Scorpia wasn't present again, called away by Hordak for another briefing, leaving her with Adora who was slowly recovering. She got Adora onto the bed, and moved over to Scorpia's desk. She could go back to her quarters once she knew Adora was asleep.

Eventually, Adora sat up on her bed. Her legs still shaking, she walked over to her locker. As a Cadet Champion, she got a small amount of privacy not afforded normal cadets and withdrew a large bundle, piling several items Lonnie couldn't see onto it. Adora turned to her, this bundle of cloth clutched close to her chest, and said, her voice still trembling, "Do you have anywhere we can go? I don't want Shadow Weaver to find us." That was curious, but she knew a place. She nodded once and turned to leave. Adora followed her still on shaky legs.

The journey up the side of the main compound to a small overlook no one ever came to was quiet. She found this place while practicing spells to cushion her fall. Her mentor had recommended she find a smaller tower, but this was perfect. You could only really learn in the moment. If she failed, the fall would have killed or injured her, but she had studied the theory and practiced the simple gestures. She had landed safely in front of

Isolde going just fast enough to only bruise as she hit the ground. At which point Isolde had demanded she go again. Since then, this tower had become her little haven; no one had been up here except for her in a decade. It took over an hour so it was well past midnight when they reached the top with Adora's shaking legs and clutching her bundle, her *kiari* still strapped to her belt.

As they reached the top, Lonnie sat gesturing towards a comfortable bit of metal near the railing for Adora to rest against. She then turned to look up. From this vantage, you could almost see through the worst of the smog of the Fright Zone to see the moons above.

They sat there for a moment, Adora staring up in wonder. Eventually, with her hands now only barely shaking, she reached into the bundle she had carried carefully up here, removing a pad of paper and a small, electric razor, one used for shaving cadets when there was a lice infestation. She spoke in a quiet voice barely above a mumble so much that Lonnie had to strain to hear it. "I wanted to ask if you could shave my hair?" It was such an earnest request.

"What? Why?" she asked, dumbstruck. Adora looked up at her pleading with her grey-blue eyes. She shuddered and held out both the pad of paper and the razor again. Lonnie took both without breaking eye contact.

"I feel wrong…" Adora started then stopped. "I just, I don't know why? I keep thinking about training, and the tomb, and everything. I want to win, I want to be strong like you, I want to stop being afraid of… of her." No prizes for guessing who 'her' was. "I drew this," she pointed at the paper. Lonnie glanced down at it.

Shit.

On the piece of paper was a small, flowing sigil, complete nonsense to most, even Shadow Weaver had never bothered to translate it. But Lonnie had a book somewhere in her personal

collection that had this symbol: it was the flowing script of *Aiilayra.* She had definitely seen it before, she even knew what the literal translation was, she just had to remember. "I just want to reclaim some part of myself, and this," she gestured at the symbol, the razor, and then at the short cropped hair on the side of her head. "I just…" Her nose was bleeding.

Lonnie knew this was a problem, but this was going to fall apart from the first moment she came back. "Alright, just stay still." She activated the razor. Her hands were meticulous and steady as a surgeon. She shaved the symbol into the side of her squadmate's head all the while trying to recall the information of what this symbol meant.

It was near the end as she racked her brain that she remembered. Her mentor had demanded that she read not just books of magic, but of all topics—you never knew when an odd scrap of knowledge would save you. One book she had acquired through a Scorpioni merchant was a well-regarded journal of a Magicat merchant who made trips to Salineas and beyond. They had journaled the long trips in the past and written them in both *Aiilyara* and in the common Etherian tongue to act as a translation for those who wanted to learn the written text and to understand a Magicat's perspective. Shadow Weaver thought she had every copy burned, but Lonnie had saved a pair. At one point, this symbol appeared when this merchant was wandering the Crimson Wastes, and it's literal translation was: '*I wish for the trees of home though I may never see them again.'* She finished it up with a quick flourish before pulling out her sword polished to a mirror shine to allow Adora to examine it.

She smiled and it was the same goofy, radiant smile of their youth. Her hands still trembled but only slightly as she reached into a bundle and produced a small sheet of thin paper and a crushed up set of dried flower petals like she had seen in alchemy practice. Adora placed the thin sheet of paper down and placed the crushed flowers into it, rolling it into a cylinder with a practiced skill. She tied off the ends and held it out and said "Can you light this?" Her voice gained back some confidence. "I'll

share.” Share what? She conjured a small flame on the tip of her finger and Adora held one end of the paper over it causing it to begin to burn.

After a few moments, the smell of burning leaves hit Lonnie and she remembered a small workshop, and a garbled voice talking, this smell all around her as she was held by strong calloused hands. She remembered a figure taller than any she had seen—or had she just been small?—laying on a soft chair long enough for three people, a beam of day moonlight illuminating the chair and this smell wafting from a piece of similar paper.

She was shaken from her memory, which was already fading, when Adora took the stick of paper out of her mouth and handed it to her. She followed the movement, putting it in her mouth and inhaling, only to cough up. It was like inhaling smoke from the battlefield. Adora had done it without even blinking but it had calmed her. Lonnie tried again, this time taking a smaller inhale. She felt her muscles begin to relax.

They spent the next half an hour passing the small cylinder of moonflower—she recognised it from it’s effects backwards and forwards. Technically, it was contraband but Adora never broke the rules before, so she wouldn’t begrudge her this. Plus, if she could find out the supplier, she could get some for Kyle. It was supposed to help with anxiety. They finished it and just sat there, Adora looking calmer than she had in months, not even this calm whilst holding her *kiari* and fighting.

“Thank you, Lonnie,” she said to break the silence. “I… I don’t know how many more times I can face the dark, but knowing I have my squad behind me. You and Scorpia. I saw you stand up to Weaver for me…” She trailed off.

“Do you want to know something, Adora?” Adora sat up, leaning in slightly, as if it was a conspiracy. “I think she’s afraid of us, of you and of me. One day, she’ll be forced out and it will be one of us taking over.” Adora smiled at her. “If you can learn to

master your powers, you might even be able to beat me to running this junkyard." She laughed at that and Adora pouted.

Then she did something unexpected: Adora leaned forward and pushed her forehead against Lonnie's, her eyes closed. It was an achingly familiar gesture but one she couldn't place. She just knew it meant that Adora trusted her. A gnawing pit opened in Lonnie's stomach despite the buzz in her head from the moonflower. Adora trusted her and she was lying to her.

Adora looked up at her then reached down to the bundle itself tied with string. She held it out to Lonnie "I made you this." Lonnie took it and untied the string. The thing unfurled to reveal a thick, blue cap, the edges trimmed in some silver thread. On the back was a pattern made of the same silver of a castle standing in front of the shooting star of Mystacor.

"I know Knights have their own sigils, and that you technically proved yourself as a Mystacoran Knight by beating one of their Knights in single combat using their magic. So, I thought, what better than the Knight of the Fright Zone having her own sigil in mockery of theirs. The castle is for—" she was rambling.

"I know what it means, Adora." she snapped, but she was smiling. This was… This was beautiful. It was what she was missing, proof of her knighthood. Some small part proving who she was, and what she had done to earn her spot. "I… Thank you."

"I made small patches to go over our uniforms for me, Kyle, and Rogelio. All wearing that sigil. I thought it could be for our squad. Even if we're all being separated. You went the furthest of all of us. Helped us when I couldn't," she continued rambling.

"Adora!" she said softly. "It's perfect. Come on. Let's get you back to the barracks before Scorpia freaks out." For just tonight, she could pretend that everything was fine between her and the girl who had run away.

Chapter 5: Missing Lizard

Chapter Summary

Rogelio has been sent down in the dark, never to return.

Lonnie's Chamber

The New Fortress

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

It had been two weeks and Lonnie was getting anxious. Two weeks since Rogelio had taken the task that Callix had offered, a chance to fight in Subtheria and earn some glory. She couldn't turn him down, this would be his chance to prove himself a warrior of the Horde.

So, Lonnie had let him go down into the dark where whole armies are sometimes lost. She didn't think she would miss him anywhere near as much as she did, but he was a constant presence, a rock she could fall back on at any time. Kyle had been spending the nights in her room ever since Rogelio had left, and today was supposed to be a check in, as well as a test of the new software R&D had cooked up to break through the interference caused by being so far underground.

The first check in four days ago had gone smoothly; Callix's team had made contact with one of the goblin tribes down in the dark and had set up a forward outpost, a short journey by skiff from her own fortress through occupied tunnels to reach the outpost which made her tower the closest point for resupply and was the rendezvous should anything go wrong. She relaxed only

slightly at that confirmation. The fortress was nearing the end of it's construction and with it her own obligations to remain in the Fright Zone permanently.

She was now onto the process of training troops, selected from the best of the cadet corps and veterans of the Subtherian campaign. She wanted to have a personal hand in their training and Cobalt was happy to oblige her. Soldiers of the Horde trained to fight in Subtheria and in the halls of the Fright Zone and its newest fortress led by the Knight of the Fright Zone herself and with Hordak's personal blessing—she had named them her Bulwark. They were growing into an elite force with a reputation beyond the Fright Zone's borders. Hordak had issued special gear and many wore her sigil on their left breast. The star and fortress was becoming synonymous with the unbreakable nature of the Horde.

Since that check in, though, there had been no further contact with the strike force. Details of their mission were sparse; Callix and Shadow Weaver keeping their plots secret from all others lest anyone else try to claim credit for a success or worse disrupt a plan and have its architects fall out of favour. Lonnie tried to focus on her mission rather than the petty feuds between warlords.

Today marked the next check in for the unit, to confirm needs for resupply and to provide mission details. The breaching software should allow them to reach the radio down in the depths of Subtheria and the hardware both the forward base and the fortress contained was more than strong enough to pass clear communications between the two.

She stared at the digital clock. Check in was at fifteen hundred hours, and it was currently thirteen - twenty eight. An hour-and-a-half later, she checked her tablet again. She had a few brief communications: some about supplies for the fortress and the Bulwark, a *'requisition request'* from the quartermaster for Adora, a message from Shadow Weaver demanding attendance this evening. All things she could file away and ignore.

She answered a few with some quick responses. Affirmed to Shadow Weaver that she would be present at the meeting, and then looked again. Thirteen - thirty one. This was going to take a while. She grabbed her foci, sent a message along to the quartermaster, and stepped out. That would waste an hour.

It was a short journey from the fortress to the main compound —twenty five minutes by skiff. That left her with just under an hour to pick up what she needed. The walk to the quartermaster's office took her ten more minutes. The big lizardfolk always had time for her; she traded in good, honest, plundered coin, and supplies in exchange for items for her team. Often stuff that never reached the official ledgers.

Everyone knew about the black market that traveled throughout the Fright Zone. Ration bars were often supplemented with 'liberated' foodstuff from the frontline, smuggled back to the main compound. Batteries were always in demand, spare weapons, extra water rations, you could find it all on the underground market. Today was a regular collection plus a special item.

The first was very much blackmarket goods: moonflower was grown in Plumeria and the soldiers on those outlying villages took boxes of the stuff as loot. Some of it made its way back to the Fright Zone, and into circulation amongst the infantry.

She normally would not have looked twice at the stuff, but Adora had a fondness for it stemming from her time underground, and they had made something of a ritual of smoking it together. She had even given some to Kyle before anything important to calm his frayed nerves and it seemed to help somewhat.

She only occasionally partook, wanting to keep her senses mostly sharp but around Adora she was able to relax slightly. Never completely, or else she might slip up and say something she didn't mean to which could send this carefully constructed lie tumbling down like so many deactivated bots rolling off the training chasms.

The second item was more personal, and also above board. Adora, like Duncan, had taken to carrying her fancy practice sword around with her everywhere she went. It didn't take much bribing to get a decent bit of leather and a sheathe together that would fit her new blade, a fancy new baldric to celebrate a complete year under Duncan's tutelage.

She had taken great care in getting the measurements for both Adora and the blade itself. Adora clutched the thing tightly at nearly all times, and simply looped it through her belt when she needed both hands free. As far as Lonnie was aware, Adora slept holding the thing like Lonnie did Kyle. It was her lifeline in this place, her training and whatever the assassin was filling her head with was what kept her sane. She would help keep that illusion up, for now.

The quartermaster traded her the goods she asked for with no one the wiser. When a Force Captain or the Knight of the Fright Zone entered, he put aside what he was doing to assist them. Rank had privileges like that. She took the new strap of solid leather with a good Fright Zone steel loop that would slot over a shoulder and carry the *kiari*. It wouldn't fit her own blades which hung at her belt, long and curved as they were. This was for a slender, straight blade.

With it collected, she made the journey back to the fortress, all with five minutes to spare before the check in. Kyle had arrived a few minutes before and had taken a seat at the desk by all of the equipment. She stood against the corner waiting for the signal. She smirked down at her partner as he fiddled with dials and buttons on the console before him.

The clock ticked over—fifteen hundred hours exactly. The sound of silence was deafening. She stared at Kyle, who stared at the machine. He switched something and the noiseless room filled with static. But no discernable voice. Fifteen-oh-one. Kyle looked at her with a mouthed "Delays?"

She started to pace. Rogelio would be fine, he was a warrior of the Bulwark, one of Shadow Weaver's elite unit; he could push her on his better days. He was with an entire army of bots and trained troops from Calix's division. Fifteen-oh-five. She moved over next to Kyle the second they heard a voice emerge from the console at fifteen-oh-seven.

"Ambush on our forces" (Static broke the line, the sound of a raging fire) "Never seen anything like it." (There was shouting behind whoever was speaking. A retreat being called.) "The cat hybrids down here have a fucking Princess!"

The call cut for a moment, and Kyle began to work trying to pick it back up. She took several steps backwards, almost colliding with the wall. Cat hybrids, like the ones who took Adora. *Was she spirited away to Subtheria and grew up with them? Was this their revenge for taking her?* Kyle made a noise and the sound of explosions broke her concentration.

"Set it down!" the shouted noise was the voice of Callix at some distance from the transmitter. "I've seen more organized retreats from dead men!" Suddenly, the voice got closer to the microphone. "Knight-Captain, are you there?"

Kyle handed the transmitter and receiver to her. "Callix, what the fuck is happening down there!?"

There was a heavy sigh from the rockman. "The forward base walked into an ambush. The fire Princess of the Magicats attacked in force alongside that Magicat king from a decade ago. Tore through the forward team. We have one survivor who ran back with the radio gear. We're staying down here, we'll try and bring back the bodies, but your lizard boy, he was part of the team. Footage showed him engulfed in fire. I'll send it over with the report." There was some brief tapping on a keyboard followed by his voice again "We'll need a resupply as well as a new bot battalion. Our's was devastated in the attack."

Lonnie didn't respond, the blood pumping through her ears was the only noise that could breach her, not Kyle's little sobs in the corner, not the sound of the radio, not the ticking of the clock. *Rogelio was dead. Rogelio was killed by the Magicat King and his bitch of a daughter Princess. How much more could they take from her!?*

"Please confirm Knight-Captain." The radio continued to speak. "Is this thing on? Knight-Captain, confirm request for reinforcements!" She took a calming breath, focusing her mind like she was casting a spell. 'Rage is the cutting blade that you cannot defeat,' her old master had said. She could still feel it boiling away under her skin. She would need to hit someone before the day was out. To let loose and feel herself scream in fury. But for now she could focus.

"Confirmed, General Callix. Send across what you'll need and I'll ensure you get it. Make those bastards burn." She couldn't keep the venom from her voice. Bitter and angry, she finished, "Need anything else?"

"That will be all. I'll send over the new coordinates for our fall back base. Callix out." The radio went silent. She just sat there staring at the console. Behind her, she heard Kyle sliding down the wall towards the floor. There was a ping on the nearby terminal: a new file sent over. She opened it, a small, hastily compiled report of an attack on their forward base in response to something called 'Operation: Cuckoo.'

She opened the file. There was a mission brief to capture Magicat children to test their efficacy as soldiers for the Horde. Crude but not unexpected, Lonnie thought. Then there was a breakdown of the mission itself, including bot footage of the ambush.

And there he was, the Peasant King, as Shadow Weaver had called him, twin blades in hand. Behind him was a younger woman, Lonnie would guess around her own age, fire wreathed her. Even through the separation of the screen and hundreds of

miles, Lonnie could feel the heat of those flames, especially as she cast a spell with a thought—no incantation or gesture was required like only a Princess could—and summoned a wall of flame which surrounded the lone lizardman, Rogelio, her rock in the storm. Consumed in a tidal wave of fire.

She felt tears pricking her cheeks. This was what Adora came from, where she wanted to go back to even subconsciously. Her hands clenched and unclenched as she rolled her shoulders, the weight of the baldric, her gift to Adora, was still across her shoulders. *Would Rogelio be dead if Shadow Weaver hadn't brought Adora back?*

This farce has gone on long enough! The thought struck her like a hammerblow. She stood and strode towards the exit, hands clenched around her swords.

Duncan's Tenemos

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

Adora was working through a standard kata with Duncan, a practiced form which came to her as easily as breathing or walking. Flowing from motion to motion. Duncan had often complimented her on her skill.

The *kiari* in her hands felt almost right; Duncan had given it to her on the first day of her training. It was almost perfect, off in her hands by less than a hair's breadth. One day soon, she would forge her own; Duncan had sworn it to her that, as a practitioner of *kirith,* her *kiari* must be forged by her own hand. So advanced

was her skill that, after a single year, she would soon be ready to forge her own.

Adora finished the form at the exact moment Duncan did, not one hair out of place. She turned to face him, bowing one hand behind her back, her *kiari* raised upwards.

"Excellent work, Adora. You have grown remarka—" His word was cut off by a roar of fire and a deafening explosion. His body was thrown across the room, colliding with the far wall, the chains around his neck and wrists rattling.

Adora whirled about, *kiari* raised as she stared at a wild-eyed and rabid Lonnie, both her swords drawn, arcane energy crackling around her like a storm. She dared only flick her eyes over to Duncan lying prone, his skin was burnt and the manacles around his wrist glowed their strange magic. He was as tough as ~~Askar~~ old leather. But the injuries he had sustained caused the well of magic within her to flare to life, filling her muscles with strength.

Her mentor was injured and she could help. She realized all this in the half a heartbeat it took to flick her eyes from the furious Knight-Captain to her prone mentor.

By the time she had turned her attention back to her friend, it was almost too late. Only a decade of honed instincts kept her from losing her head to the Knight's blade. She jerked her head backwards, pirouetting away from the blow and bringing her *kiari* up. "Lonnie, what are you doing?"

"Shut up!" The woman lunged again, bringing both her swords round in a low arc. Adora leapt backwards, a move which would normally just result in her losing her footing and being at further risk, but with the golden light coursing through her veins, she landed with grace. Bringing her blade around towards Lonnie's collarbone, there was a sharp crack as the wood met steel. Lonnie's own blade coated in a layer of frost moved like a serpent, knocking aside the *kiari's* strike, a thin layer of mist drifted in the air around the blade.

Lonnie was furious—about what Adora had no idea. Anger was the death of skill, but Lonnie was no mere soldier. Even blinded by fury, she was a terror, and unlike any other time the two of them had dueled, Lonnie was bringing out her full might as a mage knight. Adora blocked a blow only to have to lurch her head backwards as a gout of flame sprouted from the blocked blade's tip. The burst of fire struck the ceiling deforming the metal above them, the heat curling the hair on her head.

The fire felt wrong, she remembered warmth, ~~sitting on someone's knee as they showed off tricks with fire that wouldn't hurt her.~~ This fire was burning fury, raging against her. Her nose was bleeding despite not taking a blow to the face, her head ringing with a voice she didn't recognise. She barely threw up a block against the flaming blade only to feel her thigh go cold as the blade coated in frost slashed across it. She kept her breathing steady despite the sudden stabbing pain as cold shot up her leg.

It was only at this moment she realized Lonnie meant to kill her; every blow was designed to wear her down. Duncan was breathing shallowly against the wall, her hearing so much sharper than anyone she had ever met could pick up the haggard rise and fall of his chest, and Lonnie's almost silent mutterings as she invoked more and more magic. She would have to end this quickly.

Which was easier said than done. Lonnie was a vicious fighter and was using every trick she had learnt over a lifetime of fighting in the Horde as Shadow Weaver's top apprentice. Even surviving this fight would be difficult, let alone winning it. She parried and dodged; her mastery of *kirith* kept her in the moment as her leg began to thaw, and she felt sweat bead on her brow from the sheer heat of the flames and the exhaustion of the fight. She had been deep into an exhausting practice session when this had started.

She fell back onto forms that Lonnie had drilled with her, and the two fell into a violent clash back and forth, slowly though she

was losing ground. With the strength of her magic flowing into her, she could keep pace with Lonnie's spellcraft, but not forever.

She saw her opening. It was a tiny moment in Lonnie's anger she was throwing her weight far too heavily into her strikes, it was no more than a millimetre wide and it lasted no longer than the blink of an eye. She took it, driving the *kiari* into the side of Lonnie's head with a vicious crunch.

The shorter woman was driven back, suddenly on the defensive. Blood poured out of the wound: a vicious swelling that had split around her eye. She swung several sharp swings which Adora had to move carefully to dodge as gouts of flame and blades of pure light emerged from the arc of each swing. The movement was as natural as breathing; she flowed like water between each strike. Lonnie saw her opening as she got close and swung both blades around towards her neck. Adora brought her *kiari* up to block both blades.

The golden light spilled out from her *kiari* as it met the twisting almost living fire and ice along the blades of the Bulwark —the room was for a moment brighter than the daymoon. There was a sharp and terrifying cracking sound. She threw all her weight forward, the shattered pieces of her *kiari* falling to the ground around her mixed with steel broken upon the anvil of battle.

As the light faded, she pulled Lonnie closer to her, holding her in a tight hug. "I'm sorry" she whispered, "I don't know what I did, but I'm sorry." She felt the shorter woman shaking in her grip, and then the soft *clang* of metal hitting the ground as the other blade dropped to the floor. Strong hands came up to grip her back.

"Stupid fucking sword, couldn't even manage one decent fight." Lonnie's mutterings sounded delusional. She choked on her tears as she said out loud and it came out a wail. "Rogelio's dead!" The words were a sword through Adora's heart. "He went

down to Subtheria, the whole army was ambushed, he died fighting those damned—" her jaw shut with an audible *click*.

Adora felt tears in her own eyes. Rogelio was always brave and strong. It was the four of them against the world, they were going to deploy together, take out a Princess together. He couldn't be gone.

She tightened her grip against Lonnie and felt tears pricking her own eyes. No wonder Lonnie was angry, ~~she was feeling the same grief that she felt~~, she had just lost the love of her life. Love in the Horde was rare, and the Princesses had taken that away in their destructive nature. Why Lonnie tried to take that anger out on her she still couldn't fathom.

She pulled back only slightly when Lonnie stopped shaking and her hands loosened from Adora's back. As she stepped back, Lonnie straightened, wiping her eyes. Even here in the *tenemos* safe from Shadow Weaver and all the others, the truth remained: *show no weakness*. Not even for each other; it was a momentary thing, that hug. It had passed.

With trembling hands, Lonnie leant down and retrieved her one remaining sword. Staring for just a moment at the mixed fragments of metal and chips of wood on the ground, thousands of them all mixed so thoroughly it would be near impossible to separate them.

With her free hand, she reached over her shoulder and unstrapped a leather harness. It was a simple length of leather, with a metal banding through which a straight blade could have been inserted, the only pair of which that Adora knew of in the Horde were lying on the ground near the slowly recovering Duncan, and shattered like glass upon the floor. "Useless gift anyway," Lonnie muttered as she handed Adora the length of leather—a baldric of a swordswoman. She looked up at her, eyes red rimmed. "You should never have come back to us." Adora felt that like a punch to the gut, suddenly every wound she had taken in the fight was like a lead weight strapped to her.

The last thing she thought before she tumbled to the ground amidst the shards of metal and splintered wood was, *Did I go somewhere?* Then consciousness left her and she dreamt again of a Sword and a cave and screaming fire surrounding great stone.

Chapter 6: Cracks in the Façade

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia starts putting the pieces together as everything slowly but surely comes to a head.

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

Scorpia wasn't normally a believer in conspiracy theories—apparently, some people thought that her people had a secret base on one of the moons which was just *absurd*—but she was starting to get the sneaking suspicion that her cadet was the target of one.

It had all started with that almost completely redacted medical file and her suspiciously normal service history. It had taken Scorpia a fair bit of time to subtly poke and prod at both of them but what she found just added more red flags to the pile.

Or, rather, what she *didn't* find.

No one had any information about Adora from before her arrival in the Dark Temple that wasn't from nearly twelve years ago. She had even talked to Kyle and Rogelio but both of them had been oddly cagey (well, *Kyle* had been cagey while Rogelio had remained impassive and deflected her questions). The most

that she had managed to get out of them (Kyle) was that Adora had been taken away for some secret training by Shadow Weaver when she was five years old.

That didn't match up with her service history nor did it match up with the stories that Adora told. In fact, *Adora's own stories* didn't always match up with her service history. Several of them were even *contradictory* once Scopria started to try to build a timeline.

Scorpia had briefly entertained the possibility that Adora had been trained as some sort of black ops agent and that her training now was somehow a part of that but she had quickly dismissed that theory. She prided herself on being a good judge of character and being able to accurately read people and Adora just came off as too sincere and earnest for that to be the case.

Unless Adora just so happened to be one of the greatest actors in all of Etheria but that seemed unlikely.

Then there was the matter of Adora's swordsmanship skills. Scorpia was there for just shy of all of Adora's training sessions with Duncan (and was even learning some things from him herself) and someone didn't get as good as Adora was without some *serious* training. Training that, once again, wasn't on her service record.

While Duncan wasn't allowed to ask about Adora's past training due to the slave collar, Scorpia *could* and so she had. Scorpia remembered that conversation vividly.

"Hey, Adora, where did you learn to fight before you started training with Duncan?" Scorpia had asked one evening in the barracks. No one else was near them and Scorpia was talking softly (Adora had *really* good hearing) so she wasn't worried about being overheard just in case.

Adora had perked up, an excited look on her face as she said, "Oh! I trained under A—" She had then flinched violently and held

her head in one hand before giving Scorpia a pained and apologetic smile. "Sorry. Headache. You know, it was mostly just basic training with some pointers here and there by some of the older cadets. Nothing special. Why do you ask?"

"No reason. You're a *really* good fighter," Scorpia had said as casually as she could while adding yet another flag to the pile.

Adora had smiled bashfully and replied, "Thanks. I'm not *that* good, though. I still have a *long* way to go if I want to match Duncan or catch up to Lonnie."

Scorpia hadn't been too certain about that then and was even less certain of it now. When she had privately asked Duncan about it one day, Duncan's response had been this:

"She's definitely had training with someone else; a *lot* of training. I frankly don't have much to teach her and have just been helping her hone the skills that she already has. If she keeps up the pace that she's on, she'll be my equal in terms of skill in another year or two."

"How does she hold up compared to Lonnie?" Scorpia had asked.

"Lonnie's growth as a fighter is also good but give Adora another three months at most as they'll be equals."

That conversation had happened four months ago and, indeed, Adora and Lonnie were now evenly matched in terms of sword skill. Scorpia had even noticed the increase in effort that Duncan had to use whenever they sparred.

No one in the Horde had skills like Adora, Duncan, and Lonnie, as far as Scorpia was aware. The Horde had some *very* skilled fighters, don't get her wrong, but those three were in an entirely different league. The idea that Adora had gotten there so quickly simply through basic training was as ludicrous as Scorpia's people having a moonbase.

Then there was Adora's chronic headaches and the pattern to them. Whenever Adora started talking about her past—usually where she learned something unusual—she'd start talking only to flinch and complain about a headache before saying something else. There were also times where Adora wouldn't even be talking but would suddenly get this far away, almost glassy look in her eyes before, again, flinching slightly and sometimes complaining about a headache.

Lastly, there was the lichtenberg scars around Adora's temples. Exactly one person in all of the Fright Zone (as far as Scorpia knew) wielded lightning magic like that and that person was Shadow Weaver.

All of this led Scorpia to a single, inescapable conclusion:

Adora was taken from the Horde nearly twelve years ago, was returned to the Horde about a year ago, and had her memories altered by someone (Shadow Weaver) to make her think that she had never left.

It was insane but it was also the only thing that made any sense. Scorpia felt like she was going crazy, that maybe there was some other, more reasonable explanation that she was simply somehow missing.

Why would someone *do* that? What was it about Adora that was so special that Shadow Weaver would jump through an unknown number of hoops just to get her back? Was it her celestial magic? Scorpia didn't know much about magic but celestial magic was supposedly very rare and *very* powerful.

Even if it *was* because of her magic, the idea that Shadow Weaver had taken Adora from her home for nearly eleven years and then tampered with her memories left Scorpia more than a little disquieted. There was just something about messing with something as important as a person's memories that made her skin crawl and her carapace itch.

What's more, Scorpia was pretty certain that she knew where Adora had been during those intervening years. It was nearly twelve years ago now that a Magicat appeared out of nowhere right in the middle of the base and wreaked all kinds of havoc before leaving. It was also about a year ago now that a relatively major offensive was launched in Subtheria. When combined with Adora's tendency to behave like a cat, that left only one place for Adora to have likely been:

Halfmoon.

If Scorpia was right about this—and she was becoming more and more certain that she was with each passing day—then this wasn't something that she could abide by.

Scorpia liked Adora quite a bit. Her cadet was a hugger like her, she was very physically affectionate in general, she had a warm personality, and she seemed to naturally try to find joy in everything. Frankly, Scorpia was starting to see her less as her cadet and more as her little sister.

As if all of *that* weren't bad enough, what Shadow Weaver was doing to Adora with her "magic training" was just *beyond* inhumane; it was just torturing Adora for little-to-no gain. Not that Scorpia would be okay with it even if Adora *was* seeing gains from it. The state Adora was left in every time she came out of the tomb simply broke her heart.

(Scorpia wasn't entirely sure how someone who grew up underground could be afraid of the dark but she was going to blame Shadow Weaver for that, too. Even if she was wrong, it wouldn't really matter.)

But what could she do about it? Scorpia didn't know how to break the spells on Adora's mind. The only people in the Horde who could likely do such a thing were Shadow Weaver (who obviously wouldn't do it) and *maybe* Lonnie (who Scorpia didn't trust even though Adora *did).* Mortella also might be able to do it

but she was out for the exact same reason that Shadow Weaver was.

That left people outside of the Horde and exactly one name immediately sprang to mind:

Castaspella, the Mad Sorceress of Mystacor.

Now, after all of her talks with Duncan and her observations of Lonnie and even Adora, Scorpia was starting to believe that the whole "mad sorceress" thing was mere propaganda. Of course, even if it *was,* it didn't help Scorpia any since it wasn't like she could easily contact Castaspella or *anyone* from the Rebellion, for that matter. Even if she *could,* it was highly doubtful that they'd help out without expecting something in return. All of this led Scorpia to another inexorable fact:

The only way to get Adora the help that she needed was to abandon the Horde and join the Great Rebellion.

Scorpia couldn't believe that she was starting to flirt with the idea of treason like this but she *was.* While Adora was doing an admirable job finding joy in the moment, there was no joy to be found in her situation and Scorpia was beginning to realize that there was no true joy to be found in hers, either.

The things that Duncan was telling them were starting to cause doubt in Scorpia. Her grandfather had gone mad due to the Black Garnet, sure, but the world around them showed that not every person who bonds with a RuneStone goes mad. In fact, the only other example that the Horde had was that one Princess from long ago who went mad with grief and lost control of the Spirit Ember, burning her kingdom to the ground. That was a whole two examples of what the Horde was saying and they weren't even demonstrating the same thing.

The world beyond the borders of the Fright Zone as described by Duncan was nothing at all like she had expected given everything she had been told and shown while growing up. It

wasn't some nightmarish dystopia ruled by power-mad Princesses, it was a beautiful, if messy, place. It was a place where one didn't have to look too hard in order to find joy.

But her own thoughts about such things mattered little right now. What was important was Adora and Scorpia needed a second opinion to make sure that she wasn't going crazy. That was how she found herself in Duncan's *tenemos* while Adora was preoccupied with other things.

"Duncan, I think something's going on with Adora," Scorpia said after a quick greeting.

Duncan grunted and took a drink of water before saying, "If you're talking about how her memory's been altered then I agree."

Scorpia's eyes went wide at that even as a wave of relief washed over her. "You mean you know?"

"I suspect," Duncan corrected. "The same as you do, I'd imagine."

"Is there something we can do to help her?"

Duncan grimaced. "Well, if we could get her out of here, I could contact a friend of mine and see if she could do anything about it. While we're here, though? I'm not entirely sure. Best thing I can imagine would be to try and help her remember. Do you know anything about what her real memories might be?"

Scorpa nodded. "I'm pretty sure that she was taken from the Horde when she was five and raised in this place called Halfmoon. The only things that I know about it are that it's located in Subtheria and is the home of the Magicats."

"Halfmoon, huh? I wonder…" A thoughtful look came over Duncan's face for a moment before he shook his head. "It doesn't matter. We need to be careful when dealing with this. If we were to just mention this Halfmoon outright or try to seriously force the

matter, it might cause a sort of backlash that could potentially do her more harm than good.

"I think that this is going to require a more subtle hand both to avoid hurting Lady Adora and also avoid the eyes of that witch. If she suspects that Adora's starting to remember too much, she'll just suppress her memories again and we'll be back where we started at best."

Scorpia hummed in thought for a moment as she considered this. "So, we just need to sort of nudge her memories in the direction of Halfmoon? Poke at the holes where things don't make sense?"

Duncan nodded. "That's precisely it. Mind, this is all just guesswork on my part. Educated guesswork given some of my connections but I'm not a sorcerer. I could be wrong about all of this."

"For whatever it's worth, I don't think you are," Scorpia reassured him. "Guesswork or not, this all makes sense to me and we can't just do *nothing."*

Duncan smiled at Scorpia and said, "Thank you and you're both right and wrong. As you can probably guess, one of the *many* things that I'm not allowed to talk about is asking Adora about her past. I'll try to nudge her memories as best as I can but, as the only one who can speak freely, it'll mostly be up to you to try and get her to remember."

The idea made Scorpia a little nervous but she nodded resolutely. "I won't let her down. You can count on me."

Duncan's smile grew as he patted Scorpia on the shoulder and said, "I know you won't, Scorpia. So long as my lady has friends like you, she'll be just fine."

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Adora felt like her world was coming apart at the seams. Her head was foggy with half-formed memories of what felt like another life. Skills that she didn't fully remember gaining, a language she didn't remember learning, names sitting at the very tip of her tongue, faces floating at the edge of her consciousness. She felt as though she had been pulled underwater with the surface just a blurry distortion in the distance, as if her head and thoughts were surrounded by wool that barely let any light through.

Then there were two specific faces that made Adora's heart hurt. One had eyes of blue and yellow while the other had eyes of just blue. One had tan ~~skin~~ fur and the other white fur. Their faces were as hazy as everything else but Adora felt such a powerful *longing* whenever they floated near her that she knew that they had to be incredibly important.

On most days, this disquieting feeling was easy to ignore but, on others, it was borderline overwhelming. This day promised to be an overwhelming one as she entered Duncan's *tenemos* with Scorpia and idly bowed to her *Ahran* after taking off her boots only to stop as she noticed that Duncan wasn't where he was supposed to be.

Instead of standing in the center waiting for them or practicing forms in front of a mirror, he was seated on a bench in the back of the room near the door to his room. He was as still as a statue, his eyes burning with hatred as he stared at the figure standing in the middle of the room.

"It's nice to finally meet you, Adora!" Mortella greeted her faux cheerfully. "I'm *so* sorry that it took so long for us to meet but I was just *so* busy dealing with a bunch of mangy cats that I haven't had the time!"

Adora had heard of Mortella before—it was impossible not to. She was Shadow Weaver's primary apprentice and was one of the sickest, most twisted people in the Horde. She had more fragments of the Black Garnet on her than even Lonnie did and was the perfect example of how magic could twist and corrupt people.

(Of course, magic could also be used to heal and protect without corrupting anyone but that was a dangerous thing to acknowledge.)

"Mortella. To what do I owe the pleasure?" Adora said evenly as she carefully walked further into the room and to the side. She positioned herself in the perfect spot to charge either at Mortella, to Duncan, or back to where Scorpia was standing by the door depending on how things went.

Now that Adora was in a better position, she noticed that Duncan was being held in place by magenta lightning as sickly, red-grey light emanated from the shackles around his wrists and the collar (Don't think about it) around his throat.

"What, I'm not allowed to see Mother's returned, favorite toy? Or did all of your time underground leave you without any manners?" Mortella asked with a mocking giggle as she idly twirled in place.

Adora suppressed a flinch as a bolt of pain shot through her head. Returned? Time underground? What was Mortella talking about? She had never left the Fright Zone and had never served in Subtheria or *any* campaign, for that matter. She hadn't even left the main compound!

Right?

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora noticed Scorpia tense from where she had been setting out the training gear even as the anger in Duncan's eyes grew hotter.

They were hiding something from her; Adora had known this for some time now. She didn't know what or why but there was some secret, some observation concerning her that they refused to talk about directly. She didn't know why but it had something to do with her past given the way Scorpia kept obliquely hinting at certain things and prodding for details about it.

Maybe now was the time for Adora to *finally* get some answers.

"What are you talking about?" Adora asked. "I've never left the Fright Zone."

Mortella downright *cackled* at that. "Oh, Mother did *amazing* work with you. *Of course* you've never left the Fright Zone! You've spent every moment of your life here, haven't you? Never once set foot in dingy, old Halfmoon."

Adora couldn't stop the full-body wince as it felt like someone was stabbing her brain over and over again from every direction. She brought a hand up to clutch at her head even as she just barely managed to keep her eyes open.

"W-what—"

Mortella giggled again like she had just heard the funniest joke. "Oops! I said something that I shouldn't have, didn't it? Oh well! I'll be sure to send your head back to those mangy cats!" With that, Mortella lashed out with a wave of her arm and sent a ribbon of magenta energy straight for Adora's neck.

Everything slowed to a crawl as Adora watched the spell inch towards her. Off to one side, Scorpia's eyes were wide with fear as she rushed towards Adora. She wouldn't be able to make it in time. Off to the other side, Duncan's expression turned from rage to despair as he could only watch.

Adora's head hurt *so much.* Nothing made sense anymore. Everyone was keeping secrets from her. Duncan. Scorpia. Mortella. Shadow Weaver. Even Lonnie was hiding something from her. She was alone here; no one trusted her enough to tell her everything, to tell her why she kept getting headaches, why her world was so hazy, why nothing made sense anymore.

Maybe it wouldn't be too bad if she just let—

Adora!

Adora's eyes went wide as her instincts kicked in. She moved her head to the side in time to stop the ribbon of magic from taking her head but she heard a snap and felt her shoulder-length hair fall around her as the band holding her ponytail in place was cut.

Adora's eyes blazed an electric blue as gold burned under her skin and through her hair and her vision was filled by a red-gold light tinged with copper. In a flash, Adora was on Mortella. She drew her *kiari* in tandem with her steps and lashed out with a strike in one fluid motion. Her wooden blade—now wrapped in gold—*slammed* into Mortella's side, making her cough up spittle.

Before Mortella could recover, Adora drew back and lashed out with a thrust to her stomach that folded her in half. She then followed that up with a rising strike to her jaw that stood her up straight again even as it snapped her head back. Adora finished her combo with a spinning diagonal slash to Mortella's chest that sent her tumbling to the ground.

For the first time in what felt like forever, Adora's mind was clear. There was still so much that she couldn't remember but she *could* remember learning the blade from a tiger and a bear of a Magicat who was gruff yet kind. She remembered learning magic from a kindly, older woman who Adora saw as her own great-grandmother (not that she could remember what a great-grandmother *was* in that moment).

Most of all, she remembered two *beautiful* voices calling out to her, commanding her to *fight.*

"You should give up now while you're behind, Mortella," Adora said as she flourished her *kiari.* These weren't the words and actions of the kind of warrior that Duncan was teaching her to be but they felt *right* in a way that almost nothing did these days.

Off to the side, Scorpia had stopped trying to run to Adora and was now looking on at her in awe.

Mortella let out a cry of frustration as she floated back to her feet, her staff appearing in her in a pillar of red-black smoke. At the same time, spiked bands of magenta light wrapped around Adora's arms, legs, and chest, binding her in place.

Adora just smirked.

Now on her feet, Mortella pointed her staff at Adora and started to summon black and red mist to its tip before thrusting at her, the mist turning into a writhing column of smoke. It rushed at the still-smirking Adora who simply took the deepest breath that she could, threw her head back…

And *roared.*

Gold energy shot out from Adora in a dome, instantly obliterating the bindings and dispersing the smoke before blasting Mortella painfully into the wall behind her. Adora's magic went on to harmlessly wash over Scorpia and Duncan, healing any lingering aches or pains that they may have had while also freeing Duncan from the spell holding him in place.

Mortella groaned as she pried herself off of the wall but she didn't get far before Adora was on her again. A slash to the wrist got her to drop her staff which Adora then swung at. The instant her *kiari* made contact with the staff, Adora channeled her celestial magic into it, causing it to explode in a shower of splinters.

The very clearly panicked Mortella hastily erected a barrier of magenta energy between them but Adora simply curled her off-hand into claws tipped with red-gold fire tinged with copper before ripping through it with contemptible ease. Mortella had half an instant to realize that she had made a *grievous* error in attacking Adora before all thought was knocked from her head as Adora's *kiari* collided with her temple, sending her back to the ground.

"I don't get it! This shouldn't be happening!" Mortella raged as she struggled to her hands and knees. She glared at Adora, her eyes full of a lifetime had hatred. Adora just casually tilted her head to one side as she regarded her with a bland expression. "You don't even know who you are! How do you have this much power?"

Adora smirked again as another memory flitted about at the edge of her consciousness. "I am who I choose to be," she answered simply before sending a swift heel kick to her face, knocking her out cold.

Silence reigned in the *tenemos* at the conclusion of the "fight." Adora let her light recede and found herself suddenly a little tired but not enough for it to bother her.

"Adora, that was *amazing!"* Scorpia praised as she rushed up to her and pulled her into a hug, one which Adora gladly returned. "Where'd you learn how to do all that? I've *never* seen you move that way!" Scorpia asked as she put Adora back down.

Adora still didn't fully remember but she *did* remember enough to say: "It's all thanks to Tiger and Askar."

"Adora," Duncan began as he turned her to face him, leaving both of his hands on her shoulders. His expression was one of shocked disbelief. "Say that second name again."

Chapter 7: Explosive Situation

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

Everything comes to a head as secrets are revealed and battles are fought.

Chapter Notes

Full disclosure: I don't fully remember what Askar looks like and I couldn't be bothered to try and find his description. If any or all of it is wrong, just say so and I'll fix it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

"Adora," Duncan began as he turned her to face him, leaving both of his hands on her shoulders. His expression was one of shocked disbelief. "Say that second name again."

Adora's face screwed up in concentration for a moment as the memory tried to slip from her grasp. "Askar?"

"Cat person? Stockily built? Grey fur? Missing an eye?" Duncan pressed.

Adora raised her free hand to clutch at her head which ached abominably. She was idly aware of Scorpia walking over to Mortella's unconscious form and stinging her to make sure that she stayed that way. "I… *think* so? I… can't really remember."

A look of relieved awe washed over Duncan's face as he let his hands drop from Adora's shoulders. "Well, that explains a lot. If Askar was the one who trained you for a number of years, it's not surprising that you came to me as skilled as you were."

"Who's Askar?" Adora found herself asking. She *hated* that she couldn't remember the answer for herself but it was a minor miracle that she could remember the name.

"He's a Qadian—I think you call them Magicats here—and he's my brother-in-arms. We trained together under the same master," Duncan answered.

Adora flinched at the word "Magicat" as more pieces of her memories—what she was starting to understand were her *true* memories—came back. While details were beyond her, she could vaguely recall a massive, underground kingdom and spending countless hours training in a place not unlike Duncan's *tenemos.*

"Hey, uh, before we continue on with this *really* big moment, what should I do with Mortella?" Scorpia asked as she gestured at the woman in question.

"Part of me says that we kill her but not only would that be dishonorable, it'd cause us *far* more trouble than it's worth," Duncan said. "Just stick her somewhere out of the way."

"Won't she just go straight to Shadow Weaver?" Scorpia asked.

Duncan shook his head. "I doubt it. Killing Lady Adora would go directly against what that witch wants and she wouldn't want to report on that *or* on the beating Lady Adora gave her."

"Yeah, I guess that makes sense," Scorpia said with a slight shrug of her shoulders before scooping Mortella up and going to do just that.

"So, my lady, what do you remember now?" Duncan asked as Scorpia left.

Adora sheathed her *kiari* in her baldric before massaging her temple. "Not much," she said with a slight grimace. "Just enough to know that my memories have been messed with. Is that what you and Scorpia have been keeping from me this entire time?"

"It was," Duncan said with a nod. "I'm sorry for hiding it from you but we didn't want to risk any sort of backlash that might cause you harm."

"It— It's okay. I understand. And thank you."

Duncan gestured for Adora to follow him and the two walked over to a bench to sit down. "What about your celestial magic? You seem to have *far* more control over it now."

Adora held up one hand and let her magic flow into it, gold burning under her skin as she idly watched. "I do. I was taught by… someone. I can't remember who but she was kind and… like family, I think."

"It's heartening to know that you were well taken care of in Halfmoon."

"Halfmoon…" Adora muttered as she let her power fade and lowered her hand. "I need to get back there. I *belong* there, not here. I've got… family, people who love me down there."

A pained look flickered over Duncan's face before saying, "Then back there is where we shall get you. It will take some time but you *will* see your home again, my lady. I promise you that on my honor."

The two sat in silence for a moment before Adora spoke up again. "You know, I'm pretty sure I can safely get you out of those manacles and that… *collar,"* she spat the last word like it was something vile.

"That's good to know but, much like with Mortella, it's best if we just leave things be for now. We don't want to alert that witch to anything that we're planning.

"I'm back!" Scorpia said as she reentered the room. "Did I miss anything?"

"Not much," Duncan began, "but I think that it's time we brought Lady Adora in on our plans."

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Things were progressing quickly and it had Scorpia more than a little on edge. Now that she had some of her true memories back, Adora's skill was on a whole different level. Not only did she actually manage to beat Duncan in a spar once, she was regularly defeating Lonnie.

While Adora's prodigious skill was ultimately a good thing, the gap that now existed between her and Lonnie was causing issues. Lonnie was becoming angrier, more violent. She was going for more crippling blows during their spars and was using her magic more. This, in turn, forced Adora to use some of her own magic in order to properly defend herself.

Then there was the matter of Adora's continued "magic lessons." She had reported that she's modulating what she can do to show slow yet steady advancement despite being able to break basically all of Shadow Weaver's spells at any moment. Scorpia didn't know where Adora got the strength to do that given the fact that Shadow Weaver was torturing her.

Adora's time in the tomb was the one thing that didn't become any easier on her. While Adora could easily call up her celestial magic to provide her own light, the trauma had long since set in. She still came out of those sessions shaking like a leaf and ready to collapse.

It wasn't all doom and gloom, though. Scorpia had already considered Adora to be something of a little sister and she had wanted to somewhat officialize that. So, she had spoken about it to Adora and asked her if she wanted to be adopted into her clan.

Adora had responded by breaking out into tears and throwing her arms around Scorpia, saying that she would *love* to be her family. While Adora had people who were *like* family down in Halfmoon, she had no actual family of her own and didn't have anyone who she considered like a sister.

Another bright spot in this madness had come in the surprising form of Kyle. With Lonnie being busy and otherwise spiraling, he had been spending more and more time around Adora and it was clearly good for both of them. Kyle was a nice guy and Scorpia *really* hoped that he survived what was to come likely sooner than anyone expected.

But that all led back to what had Scorpia so on edge lately. The plan to get Adora out of the Fright Zone was moving faster than Scorpia had expected. Duncan had finished building all of the bombs that Blue—a spy likely for Bright Moon—needed not too long ago and it was now just a matter of making sure everyone and everything was in position.

Scorpia still couldn't believe that she was committing treason against the Horde after so many years of faithful service. But she just simply couldn't sit by and ignore not just the plight of her sister but the plight of her people any longer. Her people *needed* help, they *needed* to get out from the oppressive boot of the Horde and the only people who could do that were the Great Rebellion and *maybe* whoever it was that Duncan worked for on Eternia.

Scorpia couldn't shake the feeling that everything was about to come to a head; she could feel it deep within her bones. Scorpia's life, no, the *entire war* was about to be irrevocably changed all because of the actions of a small handful of people. A fighter of Adora's skill and power alone would be enough to change the tide of the war if used properly and there was no way that Adora *wouldn't* find a way to join the war effort after she got back to Halfmoon.

Adora wasn't the only one, either. While Scorpia couldn't compare to the likes of Adora or Duncan, she was no pushover after all of the training she received from the latter and the armor that she had crafted for herself would provide her with a great deal of protection. While it was up in the air as to whether or not Adora joined the Rebellion, Scorpia *would* be. She would be the voice of her people in the greater world and she'd be bringing with her a knowledge of the Horde that few people could top.

Then there was the matter of Duncan himself. While he needed to return to Eternia for several unknown reasons, he had promised to return to help Adora if she so desired. He had also sworn to stay with Adora until her memories were restored and she was safely in Halfmoon. That meant that, at least for the foreseeable future, they'd also have Duncan on their side for any conflicts.

All in all, the Horde was about to lose a *lot* of strength and valuable assets which the Rebellion would then be gaining. While it likely wouldn't be nearly enough to win the war, it *would* make a difference.

All of this led Scorpia to the current moment in Duncan's *tenemos,* watching Duncan and Adora spar. Even as she watched, however, despite the normality of it all, she couldn't shake the feeling that things were about to change any minute.

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Adora's *kiari* blurred as she fended off Duncan's assault while simultaneously lashing out with strikes of her own. They had been going at it for several minutes now and Adora was proud of her performance. The two of them had both taken their fair share of hits but she could see Duncan faltering ever so slightly, some of his blocks being the tiniest bit off and some of his attacks coming just a hair out of place. While Adora herself was also starting to run out of steam, she was confident that she could win this one.

After another dozen exchanges, an opening finally presented itself: Duncan's block was out of place just enough for Adora to win. She slightly altered her horizontal strike to instead strike Duncan's hand, forcing him to drop his practice mace. She then stepped forward and struck him in the solar plexus with her pommel before pressing her blade to his unguarded neck.

The two held that position for a long moment, both of them breathing heavily from the exertion, before a slow smile crept across Duncan's face as he raised his hands in surrender.

"Woo! Go, Adora!" Scorpia cheered from the sidelines as Adora returned Duncan's smile and lowered her blade. The two took a step away from each other and bowed.

“Excellent work, my lady,” Duncan praised as he retrieved his practice mace. “At this rate, it won’t be long until we’re evenly matched.”

Adora beamed at the praise and opened her mouth to respond only for her eyes to go wide. She spun around towards the door just as the sound of slow, sarcastic clapping filled the room while the shadows turned darker and sharper.

“Yes, very good, indeed,” Shadow Weaver drawled as she glided into the room.

“Sh-Shadow Weaver, ma’am! To what do we owe the pleasure?” Scorpia asked as she and Adora hastily saluted.

“I don’t know, why don’t you tell me? You lot are the ones trying to hide what Adora’s capable of from me, after all,” Shadow Weaver replied as the air became heavy with malice.

“W-we haven’t been hiding anything from you, ma’am!” Adora tried. “This is the first time I’ve beaten Duncan!”

“Enough of your pathetic lying!” Shadow Weaver yelled as the shadows became as black as tar and the air became thick with killing intent. “I know that you have been hiding the true extent of your capabilities from me for some time, Adora, and whatever game you think you’re playing ends now!”

Scorpia and Duncan began to move only to suddenly stop as their movement was arrested by malevolent magenta lightning.

Adora readied her *kiari* and called upon her celestial magic, her eyes blazing an electric blue as gold burned underneath her skin and through her hair.

“Enough, Shadow Weaver!” Adora commanded, her voice echoing with power. Adora’s light burned brighter, causing the shadows to retreat into their mistress. “This is just between you and me!”

"You dare think you can defy me, foolish girl?" Shadow Weaver floated higher into the air as magenta lightning coalesced in her hands. "I shall show you your place and turn you into the perfect weapon to raze Halfmoon to the ground!"

Adora's blood boiled at the comment and her light flared brighter as a result. "I won't let you destroy my home! Halfmoon stands now and forever!"

"Ah, so, you remember that much, do you? That will make my inevitable victory all the sweeter!"

Shadow Weaver lashed out with a wave of magenta energy at the same time that Adora unleashed a wave of celestial light with a swipe of her sword. The two energies collided in the air between them in a blinding explosion that forced Adora to screw her eyes shut. Despite not being able to see, Adora pushed forward with preternatural speed, launching herself at Shadow Weaver and covering the ten feet that existed between them in an instant.

Adora's *kiari,* now a bar of molten gold, collided with Shadow Weaver's shield which Adora quickly kicked off of in a backflip to dodge the spiked bands of magenta energy that had tried to form around her. She fired off another wave of celestial light, causing Adora to scowl as Shadow Weaver's shield withstood it without so much as a crack.

Once Adora was back on the ground, Shadow Weaver summoned a pillar of black-and-magenta malevolence to crash down on Adora's head. Acting quickly, Adora summoned as much light as she could in her off hand before countering with a beam of her own. The two spells struggled against each other in a stalemate for a moment, two, three before Adora was forced to roll out of the way when Shadow Weaver poured more power into her spell.

When Adora came out of her roll, her eyes went wide and she was forced on the defensive as she battered away three streamers

of magenta energy from three different Shadow Weavers. Adora's blade blurred as she fended off the three-way assault before her eyes narrowed. With perfect timing, she fired off a beam of celestial magic in the brief gap between the attacks, the spell piercing the chest of one of the Shadow Weavers, making her fade from existence.

Adora capitalized on Shadow Weaver's brief moment of shock by rushing down one of them, her *kiari* slicing through it like a hot knife through butter. With only the real one left, Adora lashed out with a spinning strike only to growl in frustration as Shadow Weaver teleported away at the last moment.

As Adora spun around to face down Shadow Weaver once more, she found that she was more tired than she should be. Sure, she had just come off from a fierce sparring match but she was currently suffused with celestial magic. So long as that was true, she should be fine until she stopped.

"What's the matter, Adora? Running out of magic already?" Shadow Weaver taunted as she launched another ribbon of magenta energy. Adora batted it away but her reaction had just been a hair too slow, her timing just ever so slightly off and the spell that should have missed her instead cut into her upper arm.

Adora bit back a scream as the dark spell burned at her. She needed to do something big and she needed to do it *fast* or else—

Adora's thoughts came to a stop as the shadows coalesced into nine more Shadow Weavers. As one, they raised their hands and Adora knew that she had lost.

Magenta lightning coursed from the Shadow Weavers' hands and struck Adora and she knew no more.

Duncan's *Tenemos*

The Dark Temple

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Scorpia couldn't believe what she was seeing. She had seen Adora fight plenty but never like *that.* She had been a veritable blur as she had weaved through Shadow Weaver's assault like it was nothing all while emanating a nimbus of celestial power. It had been less like watching a person fight and more like watching a goddess fight.

And yet, in the end, it hadn't been enough. Shadow Weaver had slowly but surely drained Adora's magic from her before trapping her with what Scorpia thinks were illusions. Now Adora lay unconscious on the floor as Shadow Weaver relished in her victory.

Scorpia strained against the magic holding her in place, using every ounce of her strength to try and break free and save her sister. They were *so close* to leaving, they had just needed a couple more days! Just a couple more days and the bombs would have gone off and they would have had the distraction that they needed to escape.

But now Adora's unconscious form was being levitated out of the room alongside Shadow Weaver and the plan was officially shot. Scorpia didn't know what the witch had planned for her sister but Scorpia was positive that, if Shadow Weaver succeeded, she'd never see her sister again.

It was a long time after Shadow Weaver left that the magic pinning both her and Duncan in place finally faded. Once it was gone, Scorpia shook herself off and quickly made her way over to Duncan.

No words needed to be exchanged as Duncan held his arms out towards her. It was quick work to snap the manacles off of

him, the resulting magical backlash barely even registering to Scorpia, and even quicker work to tear the slave collar off.

After he picked up his *kiari* as well as Adora's, Scorpia then followed Duncan into his room where she got to work opening the magically sealed chest containing Duncan's gear while he got himself ready. They had planned for Adora to break or at least suppress the spells using her celestial magic but that plan was out the window so Scorpia settled for punching her way through, not trusting her mace in fear of damaging Duncan's gear.

Once Duncan was properly equipped for the first time in years, all that was left was for Scorpia to send the message that would kick start the end of their time in the Horde. Scorpia *would* get her sister back and they *would* escape the Fright Zone and they *would* get her back to Halfmoon. Failure was not an option.

Chapter End Notes

If you want to learn more about Blue and what the various spies in the Horde were doing, read *Flies in a Weaver's Web*.

Chapter 8: The Great Escape Part 1: Arms Master

Chapter Summary

Scorpia and Duncan launch into action to escape the fright zone.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Near the Black Garnet Chamber

The Horde Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Feeling the old magic coursing through his veins again after so long in imprisonment was ecstatic. Duncan would never complain about such things, but sparring with the princess did often leave his muscles aching far more than he would like. His age and years of being imprisoned and frequently tortured by the witch he now hunted were catching up to him. With a single incantation taught to him by the Sorceress so long ago, he felt those aches wash away, strength filling his tired muscles. It was a spark of a match compared to Princess Adora's bonfire of magical potential. It was more than enough for this, he hoped.

His distraction had allowed the Princess of the Nest to break away from the worst of the fighting, through the unnamed Horde soldiers, none of them could stop her. Nothing short of a skilled champion would slow her from reaching her sister and his liege

lady. He would simply need to keep the attention of the two that he faced on him. One was infuriated with him, the other was a brute with a mind only for violence—it should not be hard.

The greater difficulty would come from surviving this conflict unharmed. He could admit the dangers that the dark sorceress Mortella represented, infused as she was with corrupted magics and the twisted shards of the RuneStone. She would be a threat in single combat, one he was certain he could overcome, but she was not alone, and the brutish warrior Grizzlor prevented him from getting close enough to end this fighting. Grizzlor was another matter entirely; almost no skill beyond what was basic training. He was as strong and tough as Beast Man which meant that every swing of his mace, no matter how well placed, simply struck with as much force as hitting a wall of steel.

Every time he felt like he was making progress and wearing the large force captain down, Mortella's spellwork would give him room to recover while Duncan had to dodge and weave aside. Neither had yet landed a blow on him, but the prodigious strength of Grizzlor and the dark magic of Mortella meant that when they inevitably did, it would likely be the end of the fight regardless.

Duncan knocked aside Grizzlor's axe by striking the flat of its head with his mace before it could take his head from his shoulders. He then brought the head of the weapon down on the large beastfolks knee—he only grunted in pain. Grizzlor then swung a wild fist out, and Duncan didn't have the space to dodge. Instead, he got one armoured arm up to absorb the brunt of the blow, which still threw him halfway across the room.

Colliding with the far wall, the breath was pushed out of his lungs from the force of the impact. In the time it took to blink, he shifted his head and the space he just vacated was filled with a razor sharp dark light, which sheared six inches deep into the metal wall behind him.

He rolled forward taking slow, measured breaths. He came up close to Grizzlor getting within the Beastman's reach to bring his

mace up against his axe arm. The hand spasmed as he smashed his mace up into the wrist, not so much in pain but in reflex. The axe hit the ground with a heavy clattering *thud*. The way it dented it must have weighed nearly as much as Princess Scorpia's mace. No use him going for it then, he doubted he could lift it without dropping his own weapon.

Grizzlor attempted to grab him with his undamaged arm, trying to wrap him up into a tight grip close to his chest and either squeeze the life out of him or to make him a clear and easy target for Mortella's spells. He ducked under the arm and brought the mace up between the Force Captain's legs. That got a reaction as the gruff, bear-like figure howled in pain and stepped backwards away from his weapon. Lonnie had once described her plan to kill this creature, and while he didn't doubt it would work, he wondered for a moment if the Knight was too brash and overconfident for her own good. He may be forced to find out soon enough.

He moved quickly, not giving time for the beast to react as he rushed at the witch, who threw her hands out in a wild gesture, summoning a ward of arcane power. His mace slammed into it like a hammer against an anvil, there was a blinding flash of light and a great ringing sound defended the room for a moment. When his vision cleared a moment later, the ward had held barely, and Mortella was straining, the Shards of the Black Garnet glowing their magenta light across her robes. His arm rose to swing down again to break the shield and finally kill this witch that had threatened Princess Adora for years.

He felt more than heard the movement behind him. He ducked as the axe passed over his head in one smooth motion, vibrating off the shield and causing another crack in it. If it weren't for his ringing ears, he could swear he could hear Mortella swearing.

He twisted on the ball of his foot, pivoting to bring his mace up into the jaw of the unready warrior behind him. It struck with devastating force, driving the larger figure back a few steps with a

sickening crunch. Keeping his momentum with the pivot, he flowed to one side as Mortella brought her hands around into a coagulated burst of magical energy that darted right past him striking into the chest of Grizzlor and for the first time this fight throwing him from his feet.

He was already moving when the Force Captain shouted "Watch it!" from across the room. If he could close on the witch, he could end this with a single swing—she was not half the dark sorceress that her mother or Evil-lyn was. He raced across the room like a shot. Her eyes shot wide open with terror but not of him.

There was a force, like nothing he had ever felt; a tremendous pressure, the crack of lightning, and the boom of thunder drowning out the sounds of the firefight happening outside. He closed the distance ignoring it all. She had time to mutter only a single word.

His mace swung through empty air as she faded out of existence. He growled low at the woman's cowardice; it was not unexpected. He turned then to Grizzlor. The beast man had recovered and stood blade in one hand, the other pressed to his chest, clearly covering the wound. He had heard horror stories of this monster, a butcher who would slaughter the innocent for the pleasure of hearing them scream.

If he could do nothing else today, he would end this threat to the innocent people of Etheria. His hand clenched around the mace tightly. Stepping forward into a form of *kirith* that Adora had often adopted subconsciously—she was used to facing larger opponents.

Grizzlor roared in frustration and pain, charging across the battlefield, axe raised high. He was used to fighting from a tank and dealing with the odd Rebellion soldiers who survived the bombardment. He had no real skill. He could not defeat a Warrior of Eternos. Now Duncan just had to find a way through his thick

hide. He weaved between the graceless attacks like they were made by a clumsy child and not a seasoned veteran.

He dodged behind him, and slipped from his pack a device he had planned to save for later. In one smooth motion, he tucked the explosive into the loop of Grizzlor's belt.

The beast swung around again, and he leapt backwards, reaching for the detonator. He pulled it out in his free, very bruised arm—it was probably dislocated from that earlier punch based on how hard it was to move it properly. But he could still feel his fingers, which pressed down on the trigger.

The bastard had the good grace to look shocked. After decades of raining explosive destruction down on innocent civilians to know the same fate awaited him in the heartbeat between the finger hitting the trigger and it exploding. Duncan did not enjoy war, did not enjoy killing, but, in that moment, he felt a sense of victory.

He turned from the smoldering wreckage, and towards the main compound only for his sense of victory to turn to horror. The Black Garnet chamber was a beam of pure voidlight. Lightning cracked down towards the chamber a thousand times a second. Strange and crimson. He began his rush forwards. Scorpia was brave and strong but she would need all the help she could get to survive whatever that witch was planning.

Near the Black Garnet Chamber

The Horde Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Duncan's distraction had brought Scorpia enough time to get across the courtyard, just having to break through a small army alone. For her sister, she would crush anyone who stood in her way. Her mace was light in her hands, a flurry of motion that sent men, skiffs, and tanks flying across the sky.

When the two of them had met with Grizzlor, she was expecting this exactly: his tank division, twenty armoured weapons platforms designed to take down a town. At its head was Grizzlor's newest behemoth of a command tank, the *Unbreakable.* A terrifying sight to anyone, whole cities had fallen to this one division before, armies breaking themselves against the massive blaster fire. But cities couldn't dodge and weave like she could, and armies were not a furious Princess of the Nest whose carapace was hardened to be a protector. To protect her family was what she had been born for.

She hit the first of the tanks like an earthquake, bringing her mace up on its underside and flipping the thing with no more effort than a normal soldier might flip a bottletop.

That got their attention. Suddenly, every vehicle under the command of Grizzlor's second was backing up as fast as they could to get away from the woman who had always been considered the 'friendly pushover.' She charged ahead, weaving through the rain of fire like Duncan had taught her and trusting her armour to absorb any glancing blows.

She raced past the tanks, letting her mace do the work, slamming it into barrels of cannons leaving them deformed and useless, thrusters causing them to fail and the tanks to fall, and into the engines causing them to begin their detonation sequence. When someone got close to her out of their vehicle, she let her stinger do its work, at least assured they would live and just have a headache. She didn't want to kill anyone she didn't have to.

Eventually, she reached the huge armoured form of the *Unbreakable,* the only tank not retreating from her. Grizzlor's newest abomination of a command tank was twice the size of

anything else the foundry had produced, more akin to a ship of the fleet than the tank production lines. Grizzlor's constant annoyance at losing command tanks had started over a decade ago when he lost his first tank the *Knife of the Nest* to a Mystocaran Sorcerer, and in every major subsequent engagement he had lost more, until he commissioned this behemoth. Even her mace would have trouble breaking the heaviest armour of it so she dropped it to the ground. It was trying desperately to train its main gun or even the smaller machine guns on its side towards her. She would not give it a chance. Placing two pincers on the underside she heaved. It was heavy, her muscles straining so much they might pop.

Slowly, like the world was moving through honey, the tank began to tip backwards, as more of it raised into the air. She shifted to put one claw on the underside and kept tipping. Suddenly, physics was on her side as the tank reached a tipping point and she threw all her strength into a final push and suddenly it was standing up right, thrusters feebly attempting to move it through empty air. Stepping backwards, she picked up her mace, aimed at the top of the huge structure and threw. It hit the top with a resounding *clang* and the whole thing began to topple backwards. She collected her fallen mace before the *Unbreakable* hit the ground completely toppled and never to fight again.

She turned and continued her run through the mounted piles of metal corpses towards her goal. The armies of the Horde homeguard would be rallying to find the source of the explosion, if Horde intelligence didn't already know. The window in which she could safely escape with Adora was shrinking by the moment. She rounded into the corridor before the Black Garnet chamber. A guard had surrounded it, a Snakewoman with four arms holding long, vicious curved swords each dripping poison and her cronies, all medical officers—tortures who took glee in their craft—and a handful of the Horde heavy infantry holding maces in their hands.

They were waiting for her; she was predictable enough to come and rescue Adora, so they stood ready to stop her advance, Shields raised, the Snakewoman taking a deep breath. She hit

their shield wall like a mortar shell, throwing three men to one side with a single blow. One of them, a torturer, held up a syringe full of some viscous-looking liquid in one hand, and a stun gun in the other. She grabbed the wrist holding the needle in one hand, and let the stunner hit her. Her hair stood on end for a moment as she felt the two thousand volts pass through her with about as much effect as if he'd held a light bulb to her. She threw him against the wall with enough force that if he lived—and she doubted that—he would never walk again. These people were trying to stop her rescuing her sister, they were the enemy.

The serpent hit her like a hurricane of violence, each blow as strong as anything the tanks of Grizzlor's unit could produce, and whoever this lady was, she was well trained, fighting in a style similar to Duncan's. An Eternian Snakewoman with Shards of the Black Garnet wrapped in long thin chains around her wrist. Scorpia had to parry and block with her armour—who knew what that poison would do if it got into her system.

Knocking aside the flat of one blade with her mace, she stepped forward into the woman's space—a risk with her venomous fangs—and cannoned a headbutt right into her snout. She heard a vicious *crack* and she was seeing stars behind her eyes. Whatever that serpent's skull was made of was tough but the woman slithered backwards, dropping one sword and clutching a hand to her face. She spat out a sizzling gob of spit, blood, and venom… A tooth came out clattering to the floor.

Both of them shook the stars from their vision. Around them, the scattered remnants of the Horde soldiers lay dead or too injured to be involved in the fight. The Snakewoman held her two remaining swords in a tight grip, staring up at her. She looked ready to lunge, or to spit venom.

Before she could, there was a resounding *boom.* The sky above them split open as a bolt of lightning crashed down into the room behind her, the force of which tossed her to the ground. Scorpia staggered backwards, colliding with the wall.

They both recovered quickly, the unnatural agility of the Snakewoman letting her recover to her tail. She looked around at the devastation before turning her gaze back to Scorpia.

"*I will leave you to your hunt, Princessss of the Ssscopioni, but know thisss: one day, your carapace will be my new armour. You fight with the butcher of Eternosss. Sssso I will kill you, watch the Ssshadow, Princessss Ssscopia."* The woman slithered a step away and was wreathed in strange black smoke. When Scorpia lunged to strike her, her mace whistled through empty air.

The warning was appreciated, she supposed. Nice to know when someone was your enemy rather than them lying to your face like the Horde had done for years. She took a moment to check around her before rushing into the chamber beyond.

It was a tableau of carnage, the room holding the dreadful RuneStone which crackled with magenta lightning was torn apart as if a thunderstorm had struck it. Around the chamber things were half formed in strange ways: a table that once contained Shadow Weaver's reports sat half made of wood, half of something red like wine—Scorpia really hoped it was wine—that, despite being half made out of liquid, maintained its shape. The floor was bubbling and moving like a cauldron full of broth but was as solid as stone when she stepped on it. The walls once made out of steel were shifting in a rainbow hue of metals and stone. At the center of it all, the only unchanged thing in the room was Shadow Weaver.

Before her was Adora. The table she had been strapped to had become like water and she had toppled through it. Arcane energy boiled in the room like the pressure gauge on a tank. Adora lay motionless and screaming soundlessly into the empty air, golden light poured from her, while the sickly magenta light of Shadow Weaver coiled around her like a serpent. Around her wrists and her throat were shackles.

Scorpia tried to rush forwards to help her sister, but every step she began to sink into the floor. She wasn't sure if it was an

intention of Shadow Weaver's spellwork or the Black Garnet going wild with power, but Scorpia could not get more than five steps into the chamber before she was up to her neck in stone. She had to retreat, find another angle of attack. She could throw her mace, but there was a good chance that whatever was being done would affect it and it would become mud rather than steel when it got close to whatever magic was being wrought. She could go back to the other chamber and grab one of the guns off of the dead soldiers. That was the plan she decided on. She rushed back, finding one of the corpses and grabbed a standard issue rifle that had half a charge pack remaining; the other half had bounced off of her.

She was never a good shot, but even she could hit a stationary woman two dozen feet away. She fired the remaining charge, each one striking at some kind of crackling ward of energy hanging in the air. Before the final round could hit, the world lit up like the daymoon was in the chamber itself. She at first shielded her eyes with her pincers, tossing the blaster away. It began to melt in the heat. She was thrown against the metal wall of the chamber which had reverted back to steel. The light still did not fade.

She was lying on the floor face down. It was like a wave at sea frozen mid-motion. She rolled upwards. Absolutely everything hurt her and her vision was still blurry. Her pincers reached out, finding the mace sitting on the floor were it had fallen. Solid and dependable. She blinked away the light, and turned. The room was a mess, everything that had not melted had been thrown away from the Black Garnet which sat unchanged at the center of the room, a dominating feature of her nightmares untouched by the chaos it had caused.

On the floor on opposite ends of the chamber was Shadow Weaver, her body was lying in a broken state. Her back should not have bent in that direction, her head twisted in a way that Scorpia knew meant her neck was broken. At first, Scorpia was glad she was dead already, but there was the sound of bone snapping and the woman took a gurgling, choking breath. Shadows crept out of

the black garnet towards its mistress, and began to change her body back to how it was moments before the cataclysm. She could move forward, try to kill the woman, finish her off before the madness that had overtaken her grandfather brought this monster back into the world.

On the far end of the chamber there was a sob, and Scorpia turned her attention from the one woman she could admit she hated to the one person she could truly say she loved. Adora lay on the floor, the shackles around her wrist had melted to slag and left fresh burns, around her throat the collar, the collar of a slave to Shadow Weaver was tightly bound, but most strangely two huge golden feathered wings sprouted from Adora's back. Her shoulder blades supporting them were bloody and still weeping. Her face was a sobbing mess of pain beyond anything Scorpia could imagine. Her sister, changed by the very magic she had feared.

From outside, she could hear them coming: soldiers who served Hordak, hundreds of them sent to secure their second-in-command, Mortella was shrieking her orders out. She had survived Duncan and got to safety. She would have the choice: try and kill Shadow Weaver, or absolutely rescue Adora.

Her sister was light in her arms as she ran with all the strength her tired legs could allow down to the vehicle bay. They had prepared for this with her personal skiff ready to go, packed with what supplies she thought they might need. Two dozen soldiers tried to stop her on the way out—they were dead now. She had broken down the wall to the hanger bay rather than waste time getting to the door.

The place was a ruin. Someone had attacked the Fright Zone? She rushed over to her own skiff across a pile of dead and dying, Octavia's men, all lying in a heap. But no sign of the Fishwoman. Whatever had happened here was the perfect distraction. She sat Adora down in a seat, careful not to disturb her wings which were clearly agony on her flesh, then grabbed the controls.

They had enough fuel to get to Bright Moon. The Fright Zone fell away behind her at top speed.

Chapter End Notes

This was originally posted without the final few paragraphs, uh...Don't past from your phone at 1am is my advice for myself going forward.

Chapter 9: Great Escape 2: Knight Lonnie

Chapter Summary

The attack on the Horde to rescue Adora is interrupted by the Arrival of Knight Lonnie Leor

Near the Horde Foundry

The Horde Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The whole thing was a mess—they had absolutely no warning when the foundry went up in smoke. From a few miles away in her fortress, Lonnie felt it, knocking reagents off their shelves and sending her paperwork tumbling to the ground as it shook the earth. The calls for a status report were muted when she felt it, a flow of magic unlike anything she had ever experienced, coming from the Black Garnet chamber.

She had rallied her forces then, a full half of her elite, one hundred well trained warriors each of whom she had personally vetted, rallied behind her into skiffs. She had spent too long drilling them for exactly this kind of situation, knowing how vulnerable the Horde could be if someone got inside the main compound. It took eighty-seven seconds between her issuing the order and all one hundred soldiers being on their respective skiffs. A damn fine response time which she would be bringing up to Hordak in her report.

From there, it took a further three minutes to reach the Fright Zone's main compound. Aside from specialists and non-com's,

Grizzlor and Octavia had defense duty this month. She wondered how their response time was when she spotted them from off her skiff, a group of three figures, lithe and feline—cat hybrids like the one that had taken Adora—wearing a uniform of one of the Subtherian undercultures. A crest of a flame.

Lonnie drew her blades and leapt from the skiff, twisting in the air and casting a spell to soften her fall so that it was almost completely silent. She landed and was already in motion, twirling the weight of her blades in her grip. She rolled her shoulders back to straighten herself as the three figures stiffened, noses twitching as if they noticed her via their sense of smell alone.

They turned as one, drawing blades; long, thin, slightly curved things that spoke of Adora's fighting style. The cats fought with *kirith?* That made a scary amount of sense, but she had trained against a *kirith* master multiple times a week for the last two-and-a-half years. Only their leader fell into a different form, wearing an armour of white with a golden flame across the chest plate. She carried a great two handed sword.

The woman spoke, at first in the chittering language of that lost community that she had heard Adora mumbling in her sleep, though it was clear this person was far more fluent. Then switching to broken Etherian when it was clear Lonnie couldn't understand her. That was something for Lonnie to fix, get someone who spoke this *Aiilayra* so that she could understand her enemy. Her Etherian was slow and cumbersome, as if it was a completely foreign language to her.

"You will lead us to the temple daughter." She hefted her sword. "Lead us to Adora, or you will die." The other two warriors tensed. They had a look of surety to them. Clearly people picked out for a mission because of competency. Lonnie laughed in their face.

"You're not going to get Adora. I'll kill her before I let you mangy cats near her again." She held both her swords in a loose grip, she could feel the tug of magic, a quick spell to pull heat

from the air into a burst of fire. She looked over at the woman ahead of her. She had a suit of fine chains and set into the gorget was a ruby that seemed to burn with an internal fire. The Magicats had their own RuneStone? That was something to investigate.

"I will kill as many of you Horde scum as I need to save my temple sister. You will not stop us." Temple sister? An odd phrasing. Adora had faith in something Lonnie didn't understand and Adora didn't remember. But her times in the tomb had been lessened from terror to mere dread by that faith.

"She is not your temple sister, she is my squadmate, and you will never get your claws on her again." She snarled, feeling the shards braided into her hair flicker with power.

The three magicats moved as one, an expertly coordinated strike. The one on her left lunged, and she stepped to her right, the temple daughter struck with her heavy two-handed sword straight for Lonnie's head. She knocked it aside with the flat of her left hand blade, sending it up and over. The woman spun it back in a figure of eight motion maintaining the momentum. The one on the right lunged forward into the space she had dodged to—she simply flicked up with her focus and a jet of flame emerged from its tip. It lasted less than a heartbeat but the right hand magicat fell to the floor unable to scream as the air in his lungs baked.

The two stepped backwards eyes going wide with terror, their ears pinned back and tails lashing. They clearly didn't expect to encounter a sorceress. Lonnie could only smile her wicked grin. Always she was underestimated, these hybrids would suffer for it.

The one with the RuneStone fragment in her armour spoke, while the other stepped backwards out towards the wall and around her, attempting to flank her. She allowed it, it wouldn't save either of them. "Who are you, warrior? Squadmate of Adora? She spoke of her old squadmates to anyone who would listen."

Adora talked about her and the boys? That was surprising. “I am Knight-Captain Lonnie and I’m only telling you, since I’m about to kill both of you.”

The woman inclined her head slightly, ears tilting forward as if to listen. “She always said you were brave. Far braver than her, and I can see what she means. I am Lynn, Temple Knight of the Celestial Promise. It was an honour to cross blades with you, but this ends now. I will apologize to her for your death.” She felt more than heard the movement behind her. She ducked low as the blade of the other magicat whizzed over her head, she only halfway turned bringing her left hand blade up in a clean strike through the elbow, severing the arm in a single blow. The sword and the arm connected to it clattered to the ground. She kicked backwards with an iron booted foot and heard the figure fall to the ground, a few seconds later he began to scream.

Lynn wasted no time, lunging forward her blade coming down across her exposed neck. She twisted her arm bringing the still bloody blade into a clumsy but effective block. She was being needlessly reckless, the reverberation heading up her arm causing it to spasm slightly. She lashed out with the right hand blade into the armour of Lynn’s knee. The armour split but no blood was spilled as the woman leapt backwards away from her.

Suddenly, this Lynn looked worried. Lonnie didn’t dare turn from her. She was good—nowhere near her level, but as good as some champions in the Horde and with a shard to prove it. It was now one-on-one, and she could press the advantage. She lunged forward, bringing both blades up at different angles. Lynn parried the first but earned a gash on her thigh for ignoring the second. She didn’t need any more spells to finish this woman off; she would conserve her strength. Lynn brought the two-handed sword round in a disemboweling blow, but Lonnie simply danced backwards as she had been taught to do, staying outside the reach of the sword before darting back in. This time, she scored along the outside of the woman's wrist between the armoured gauntlet and the chains along her arms. It was not a deep wound, but it would hamper her ability to grip the sword properly.

With that blow, the fight was over. She knew it and Lynn knew it. It became less a challenge of slaying the woman, and more a puzzle of which piece to take apart next. Lonnie was uninjured except for a slight bruise on her palm from where she blocked a blow with too much force. Lynn's mobility had been hampered and her ability to swing that ridiculous sword was becoming slower. She moved around to keep her from having to pivot on the bleeding leg before striking again, two quick blows: one to the stomach, another to the ankle. The woman barely had time to blink before the weight of her armour and weapon dragged her down, injured leg buckling beneath her. She tried desperately to swing the sword at her from the floor. Lonnie kicked her wrist and stepped on it, a squirt of blood coating the bottom of her boot as Lynn screamed in pain.

The scream quieted after a moment into the same language she had spoken earlier, but with a cadence to it Lonnie didn't recognise, but could identify as a prayer. Lonnie took the sword that was not her focus in her hand and hovered it above the magicats eyeball. Waiting the ten or so seconds it took for her to finish. Lynn only stared up at her in mute admiration as the sword went through her head.

She left the sword in the Temple Knight's head as she reached down and plucked the gemstone from her collar, holding it in her gloved hand. She could feel the heat radiating from it, like holding a lightbulb that had been lit for several hours. She channeled a tiny amount of the Black Garnet's energy through her shard and pressed the gemstone to her belt. The leather became like clay forming around the stone and then hardening again. It would make a good buckle until she could figure out its secrets. Retrieving and sheathing her swords, she pressed on the comm link.

"Status report," she ordered down the Bastions private channel. She heard several voices all commenting on the situation or her crazy stunt to leap from a moving skiff, but her second—a minotaur named Ciran—shut them up.

"It's chaos out here, ma'am, A group of Magicats have broken into the facility. The explosion has torn apart the foundry, but none of the magicats came from there. I have a squad securing it, and the surrounding area. R&D's half collapsed." She froze at that before taking a breath. He'd be fine. She had to deal with the problem in front of her "I have every specialist I can get a hold of digging through it. But the bigger problem is what's happening between the compound and Black Garnet chamber."

"What?" Shadow Weaver was the target; the Magicats were attempting a rescue mission for Adora. So why the Black Garnet chamber? Unless Shadow Weaver was about to try something very stupid.

"Knight, it's the Princess. Scorpia has destroyed Grizzlor's tank company. It's a fucking mess out there, and we can't spot her."

Scorpia had turned traitor? Scorpia was trying to turn Adora back over to these Magicats? How did she even get in contact with them? All questions for later.

"Acknowledged. Secure the Black Garnet chamber and offer support to Shadow Weaver if you are able. Make sure R&D doesn't catch fire, there's a lot of shit in there that can explode. Find Kyle and get him out. Then get the fire squads down with suppressants to get the Foundry under control. I will head there on foot."

"Acknowledged. We'll save the best of the fighting for you. These Magicats are tough bastards. Ciran, out."

She turned and began to move just shy of a run towards the main compound. She wouldn't let Shadow Weaver hurt Adora any more than she would let these Magicats kidnap her back.

Near the Black Garnet Chamber

The Horde Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The rush across the compound revealed the sheer scale of the damage. Whoever had caused the detonation had thrown debris all across the Fright Zone. Lonnie had made her way through the wake of Scorpia's destruction. Tanks lay strewn about like ruined bots after a sim.

She spotted the group of them sneaking through the terrain—if she didn't know what she was looking for, she would have missed them. The almost supernatural skill of Magicat hunters was well regarded prior to the burning of Halfmoon, she had read, and the Fright Zone had nearly as many hiding spots as the old forest, especially amidst so many hollow metal corpses.

If they had spotted her, they gave no indication. She hoped they hadn't or, if they had, that they thought she was some technician or specialist that wouldn't spot them. The three of them crept across the courtyard with an incredible speed while maintaining their stealth.

Their leader was clear: the tallest of the three carrying a wooden *kiari* on his belt and an actual sword of similar proportions in his hand; his armour was made of a strange coppery metal and had over a dozen of the same gemstones that now sat in her belt studded across it. Surely warded against attack, even a surprise one. The second wore similar armour and carried a pair of axes, each clearly enchanted in some way she did not know yet. The final one worried her: a sorcerer trained in a school she didn't recognise. He clutched a staff tightly in his hand and faint wisps of energy floated around him as if maintaining some spell. It wasn't a ward—she could recognise those—it looked like an alarm or teleportation spell held a moment away from casting.

Lonnie would have only one opportunity for this. The previous fight had been too easy; the amount of shards this individual had marked him out as a true champion. Only Mortella and a handful of others had as many as he did in his armour, and dealing with a sorcerer at the same time, risky. She discounted the third, not out of hand, but as something to overcome quickly.

She raised her focusing sword and within a heartbeat cast her spell—it was one her master had taught her early in their career. She used it on the remains of the tank they were passing, the *Unbreakable.* The sorcerer's ears perked up and his tail lashed once but it was far too late. The tank next to him had all its remaining munitions detonated. The sorcerer was perched on the barrel when it happened, his body was incinerated and chunks flew across the ruined battlefield. The *kirith* warrior staggered but did not fall. The third was mid leap from the ruined vehicle to another when it happened. With incredible speed, she turned, throwing one of the axes in her palms out in her direction. The throw went wide by a few feet, but there was a crackle of light and the Magicat was rising out hands gripping both axes, including the one she had thrown. Lonnie stepped backwards, surprised for a moment. That was fucking neat, she would give those to Ciran when she was done.

The figure lunged forward, bringing both blades around towards her neck for a quick kill. No chance of that; she ducked low, bringing her own swords around. They skittered off the Magicat's armour due to the shallow angle. She flowed backwards, keeping herself aware of the terrain.

This dance would be dangerous. She would need to finish off this teleporting warrior before the *kirith* warrior joined in. He was running over blade in hand shouting in their native tongue into a communicator. Secrecy, it seemed, disappeared with the exploding tank, or perhaps the death of their sorcerer had spurred the call for help. Either way, she intended to kill them both and take that communicator, give it to Kyle to break their network once she was assured he was safe.

Lonnie stepped backwards smoothly as the axe whistled past centimeters from her throat before bringing her left sword up into a swing that knocked the axewoman off balance. The second her balance was thrown, she tossed her off hand axe into the air. Before she could follow up with a strike, the woman disappeared in a crackle and was suddenly falling onto her, her axe aimed at the back of her head, but she now knew the trick.

She pivoted on the ball of her foot like any good Moondancer and the woman collided with the ground behind her. She wouldn't have turned, she simply revered her grip on her focusing blade and stabbed behind her. It bit into metal and flesh but the skittering of something metal hitting a nearby structure followed by the irritating crackle told her the woman had teleported again.

Lonnie spun back to face her again. The woman was clutching her side standing against one of the tanks her axe had embedded in. With a flick of her wrist, she drew a circle of magnetism in the air and poured the full might of a Shard into it. The tank behind the woman toppled forward.

The warrior panicked and threw her blade forward, aiming right for her head. She stepped to one side, the crackle of lightning was met by the slashing of her off-hand. The woman appeared in a flash of light and a spray of arterial blood. Staggering for a second clawed hands dropping the axes and going up to clutch at her throat before she toppled to the ground.

Lonnie had no time to celebrate as the largest of the three had dropped the communicator and hit her like a thunderbolt; she had barely time to parry the incoming attack. The figure was snarling at her. He was a head taller than her and he flowed into forms she recognised from her years of training with Duncan. But this was no practice bout, it was a well trained master of *kirith* trying to kill her. She would need every trick she had ever learned to win this. That thought terrified her for a moment, but she accepted the fear into herself. She might die here but she had bled the Magicats of five of their number. The fear passed through her and she kept her form open and loose. She had trained

against a master of *kirith* but she doubted that he had trained against a Moondancer.

She danced backwards and assessed him; his glare leveled at her told her he was doing the same. She clearly showed her skill in combat and he was clearly a master, as good as Duncan ever was. His armour was made of the coppery metal that seemed resistant to magic, and he carried himself with a near perfect poise. When he spoke, his accent was gruff and strange.

"Who are you, warrior? You are no normal Horde soldier."

She laughed. "I am Knight-Captain Lonnie Leor, Bulwark of the Fright Zone, and who do I have to kill?"

He stilled from his near constant motion for a moment. "Lonnie? Adora's Lonnie?" She snarled at him as he said that. Did Adora just tell every one of these cats about their past together? "Well, Knight-Captain, I will not allow you to stand between me and my goals. Retreat now; there is no shame in it."

She laughed in his face. "I don't run for anyone." She stepped forward into one of her many practiced stances. He sighed and assumed a form she had seen hundreds of times.

He slashed outwards in a controlled swing to test her skill. She pivoted to the right, lashing out with her blade as she moved past smoothly. Her swords skittered over the armour causing sparks.

She readjusted her grip, pivoting to face him again as he turned as smoothly as Duncan or Adora ever did. In his motion, she noticed the tiniest idiosyncrasies that marred Adora's fighting style all present in his but, with the added tail, it made perfect sense.

He sighed. "I take no pleasure in killing you, Knight. You did much for Adora. But I will kill you if you stop me from getting to her."

"Of course you'd come back for her," she snarled out, parrying a slash from his blade aimed at her eye. "What's your name, then? You taught her how to fight, I assume?" She went for a low slash with her off hand; he pivoted and she used the opportunity to get in closer. The curved shorter blades she favoured were more useful up close where his reach wouldn't favour him.

He leapt backwards with an agility seen on no one in the Horde and landed a few steps backwards. The second his feet left the ground, she began to cast a spell.

"I am General Askar, and I had the pleasure of being Adora's *Ahran* for many years," he said casually as he landed, not winded at all by the fighting. Her spell hit the air like a thunderbolt, but nothing visibly changed.

"Well, Askar, I want you to know you failed. Adora is ours and you can't take her back," she snarled at him. He lunged suddenly like an apex predator taking down a wandering prey animal, but she was not prey.

The first strike would have gone for her throat had she not ducked under it, and brought her sword up against his flank, the armour once again deflecting it—she needed a suit out of whatever it was made from, she could gather it from the corpses of those she killed. Her other blade skittered along the metal ground, the spell contained within flaring to life. She dived to one side before he could adjust and struck herself.

He was wicked fast, and better than her—easily as good as Duncan was with a sword. She knocked aside his own strikes but she would tire quicker, a side effect of being an adept as well as a warrior was she exhausted quicker. But she could see it on his brow, a bead of sweat.

Lonnie kept on the offensive, always keeping one blade near his sword arm, the other striking out towards unarmoured parts of his body. It was never enough to deal more than a superficial blow. It didn't matter, the strikes were all a distraction.

She left a gap in her defenses. He didn't take it at first, sensing the trap. He was certainly a master of his craft, but she could keep wearing him down until he took the bait. It wasn't on the second, or even third "opening" she left, but on the fourth, he lunged in to strike. She twisted, allowing the sword to strike her own breastplate. Her chest rattled like falling off a story high building but she would live. She tapped the sword onto the ground as she did so and the spell was complete.

All the Shards of the Black Garnet flared to life for a moment, and the metal floor, the pipes, and wiring all burst to life like serpents of metal and wrapped themselves around the Magicat general. She twisted her focus and it forced him to the ground.

He struggled against the restraints, trying desperately to hack at the metal with his sword. She willed the metal to coil around his wrist and his chest, and then forced them to constrict until she could hear bones snapping. The sword dropped from his hand with a spasm and the metal of his armour buckled under the weight around it.

She kicked aside the sword and let it tumble to the body of the fallen Magicat with the axes. Staring down at the old warrior whose eyes weren't filled with fear but anger.

"Any last words?" She leveled the curve of the silver sword that was not her focus against his throat.

His eyes flicked over her shoulder, and the grim mask of determination turned into a predatory grin.

"Funny, I was about to ask you that!" a new voice shouted from over her shoulder.

Near the Black Garnet Chamber

The Horde Main Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The destruction had been catastrophic. Whoever the spymaster's agent was had done good work. Not that Cyrus knew anything about that agent; Halfmoon's secretive spy network was kept even from the Royal Family to "prevent them from influencing decisions." Still, their arrival and subsequent split up had allowed them to cover plenty of ground. Cyrus has left his team to secure a safe spot to retreat to and near the leylines to teleport to Halfmoon once they'd grabbed Adora.

Two-and-a-half years was far too long for any child of the Royal Family to spend in this hell, and Adora was part of the Royal Family in all but blood. He had been given some directions. Adora stayed at the Dark Temple, the home of all the champions in the Horde, and despite everything there was a swell of paternal pride at Adora, not even an adult, ending up amongst the most dangerous people on Etheria.

He had cut his way to the temple, even commandeering a tank on the way, leaving a plethora of bodies in his wake, incapacitated or killed he couldn't really care. He left a trail of destruction so the Horde would follow him and not attack the small group containing one of their only ways out. He very much doubted he could steal another skiff to escape. So, he was both the distraction and rescue plan. Only to find it empty save for the signs of battle. He had, however, picked up Adora's scent and began to follow it.

He was still following Adora's scent nearly halfway across the compound when he heard it: the sound of fighting. But no other squad should be anywhere near as close. He leapt over the small steel obstacle and saw a huge beastman currently locked in conflict with a man wielding a mace and wearing a suit of armour whose colours matched no nation that Cyrus knew of. The beast man was wielding a weapon nearly half the size of the other

warrior yet could not land a blow as the man pivoted and struck like a *Khir'saya.* He was wielding *kirith* with a mace.

Without thinking, Cyrus started his rush forward but before he could make it to assist this strange warrior. The man's mace snapped out right into the jugular of the beastman. Even through layers of muscle and fur, his body could not survive such a blow. The figure clutched its throat for a few moments before its eyes rolled back in its head and fell to the ground very dead.

The warrior took several centering breaths before raising his weapon up to face Cyrus. "Who are you?!"

Cyrus sheathed his blades, palms up in the Etherian expression of surrender. "I am King Cyrus of Halfmoon. I am looking for someone." The strange warrior inclined his head. "A young woman, blonde hair, steel blue eyes, goes by Adora." The man's face tightened in recognition.

"Who are you to her?"

"I'm her fath— her friend, I am here to take her home." He watched the other man's expression go from anger and confusion, softening slightly.

"Adora was taken by the witch Shadow Weaver to the Black Garnet chamber. My companion, Princess Scorpia, has set out to rescue her. I hope she is not too late." He pointed with his mace up at a tall building across a wide open courtyard near where he had engaged the tanks. "If you speak the truth, then I will take your assistance to free my lady." His lady?

"Glad to have you on board. You know my name, stranger, I would know yours?"

The man grunted out "Duncan" and then strode off.

It didn't take them long to run into trouble, several squads of troops each a dozen strong were converging on the Black Garnet chamber, and while between the two of them they made short

work of them, every moment delayed was a moment Adora was still captured.

Trouble really came for them when Cyrus' communicator pinged with a distress signal, the sign for a hostile sorcerer coming from Cyrus and an alert that one of their sorcerers was dead. That thinned their escape route. Clover's squad was across the compound fighting to blow up the Horde's vehicle bay to slow their war machine, she had the other sorcerer and his own squad had the final of the three they had rallied for this mission. He sent a quick message to check on his own and received an affirmative but with some worrying information: magic was beginning to react strangely in the Fright Zone. Before he could ask why, a hail of blaster fire forced him and Duncan into cover.

The courtyard was a mess, dozens of tanks lay destroyed, only two of which he could account for. Someone had got onto one of the repeating turrets and was laying down fire to prevent the two of them reaching the next courtyard where Askar was fighting some sorcerer who had killed their own. Another squad stood around the ruined tank, taking potshots.

He looked at his new companion. The man's armour had been pockmarked by the initial burst but had held. He carried in his hands not just the mace, but a standard issue Horde blaster, and a bandolier of grenades taken from each foe he had slain was around his belt. "Can you handle this?" he asked Duncan. "My men are in the next courtyard and could use some help. I'll get them and we'll get Adora."

Duncan nodded, slotting his mace into his belt. He pulled a grenade off his belt and chucked it in the direction of the tank. Before it could land, he stood and fired one clean shot, going straight through the primed explosive, showering the area with shrapnel. Cyrus used the opportunity of the distraction to bolt away, making his way through the soldiers who had fallen prone to avoid injury. He leapt over the chassis of another tank.

The sight he beheld was from his nightmares. A single warrior stood over a restrained Askar, weapon held in her hands, and the squad around them lay dead. The figure looked at Askar.

"Any last words?"

Askar made eye contact with him. Don't underestimate her, they seemed to scream.

"Funny," he decided to shout, "I was about to ask you that!" He lunged forward and the woman turned wicked fast, flowing from her execution into a third lunar dance pattern with flawless precision. This woman was a Moondancer. She was Adora's age, maybe slightly older but not by much, and he had never heard of anyone achieving a mastery of the Moondancer's blade younger than their mid twenties.

He struck out with his normal blinding speed, and the woman, so full of confidence only moments before, was suddenly backing away panicking. Her posture went on the defensive. She was very, very good, but her eyes were full of hate.

He knocked aside a counterattack and her blades were suddenly wreathed in fire which shot along like a stream hitting him squarely in the chest, a very conscious spell cast to try and kill him quickly. His armour and the many Tears of Fire he had prevented it from being a lethal strike but did force him to take a step backwards.

"Mongrel King, I know you! You are the reason I'm like this, you're the reason she was taken and I was left here!" the woman was shouting at him. He hated Mongrel King; her blame must be misplaced, "You killed," she snarled before she finished her words and suddenly the ground around him became slick with ice.

It took him a moment to dig his claws in to balance himself. She had given into her anger and he could exploit that. He leapt forward. "I've killed many Horde bastards. You're good but just the next in a long line of failures who couldn't beat me." He struck

out three times. She parried the first, danced away from the second, the third struck her collar right through the clavicle with a spray of blood. An almost certainly lethal wound.

She fell backwards and her sword dropped from clumsy fingers. The hand came upwards to press at the wound. She was an honourable and skilled fighter, she had beaten Askar and his squad before he even reached her. He stepped forward to end this Horde champion. Askar was ripping free of his restraints that went limp as she fell.

Before he could strike, a hand grabbed his wrist. The warrior Duncan held his wrist in an iron grip. He shook his head and looked at him then turned to the woman on the floor. Magic flowed through her body into a pair of spells, the first was a healing spell he could recognise, channeling magic from garnets in her hair and at her belt. Was that a Tear? Before he could reach out and take it, Duncan spoke.

"This is thanks for sparing me all those years ago, Lonnie. Live in honour. Knight of the Fright Zone, when you realize this is not worth it, come find me. This is my vow to you. You will have a place as my ally." Askar was staring, she spat a gob of blood at Duncan's feet. Then, in a veil of mist and shadow, she disappeared.

She was gone, forced to retreat to wherever her own sorcerer's sanctum was.

Askar had clambered to his feet. He walked over and stared at the strange Etherian warrior. "Duncan? What are you doing here?"

The warriors clearly knew each other when Duncan responded, "Askar, are you to blame for Lady Adora fighting as if she has a tail?"

"Where is she, Duncan?" Askar's voice was deadly serious.

“The witch Shadow Weaver has taken her to the chamber containing a RuneStone. I do not know for what purpose.” The ground suddenly heaved as if it was being rent in two. Above them, in the Black Garnet chamber, all the magic of Etheria was at war.

The communication device pinged suddenly as the sorcerer at evac point connected. “My king, something's happening to the ley lines. I’ve never felt anything like it. Magic’s going haywire. I can hold this spell to get us back for maybe a few minutes, not more. Plus the Horde have noticed our presence, the whole damned army is descending on us, tens of thousands of bots according to Jinn. Thousands of troops. What are we doing, staying and dying or leaving?”

Cyrus felt his tail lash. He couldn’t leave Adora here. Even if everyone else went, he would stay and find her. Duncan seemed to be able to read his mood. “King? Princess Scorpia has gone to rescue Lady Adora. I trust no one greater in all of Etheria than her. She will rescue Adora and kill the witch, but even she cannot escape the whole Horde army.”

Cyrus snarled at the warrior. “Then what do you suggest?!”

Duncan smiled, gesturing at the tanks around him. At least one still worked. “I suggest we get their attention, and move them away from the Black Garnet chamber, giving Scorpia a chance to rescue Lady Adora.”

Cyrus could feel his body tensing. He had to rescue her, but if he went, he would condemn them. The Knight Lonnie seemed to have sway. If she could point them to the courtyard, they would be looking for him. With a heavy heart, tail going limp, he gave the order. He would come back and scour Etheria to find his displaced daughter, but for now, they will have to retreat.

Hopping up onto a working tank, he would make the Horde bleed for his failure before fleeing.

Chapter 10: Lonnie's Resolve

Chapter Summary

As the Horde reels from the destruction caused by the Magicat invasion and Operation: Flight of Fancy, Lonnie faces her own loss and strengthens her resolve.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lonnie’s Temporary Quarters

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora’s Abduction

The Horde’s main compound was in shambles. Several points of key infrastructure were now little more than rubble, the grounds were strewn with the remains of bots and tanks, and the death count was staggering. This was easily the worst blow that the Horde had suffered since Queen Angella of Bright Moon took the field following the death of King Micah.

Lord Hordak was *furious.* He had almost immediately launched an inquisition to find those responsible for this unprecedented breach in security with the promise that heads would roll. Nearly a third of the remaining guards on duty that day had been executed for what Lord Hordak called a "dereliction of duty.”

Lonnie and her people had almost been on that list but Lonnie, her voice strained from the wound she had suffered at the hands of the Mongrel King, had managed to save them. She had stated

that it was her people who had managed to push the invaders back and that no one could have predicted a group of highly trained Magicats to teleport into the heart of the Fright Zone. Protecting the compound from magic like that was Shadow Weaver's responsibility and dealing with the Magicats was General Calix's job.

While shifting the blame had worked, it had left a sour taste in Lonnie's mouth. While she didn't care about whatever punishment came down on Shadow Weaver and Calix, she hated that it had come to that. Ideally, she would have been rewarded for successfully thwarting the invasion but she had done no such thing. She had been soundly bested by the Mongrel King, spared only due to Duncan's intervention, and the Magicats' mission had only been a failure due to whatever the hell had happened in the Black Garnet chamber.

Lonnie's abject failure *burned* at her. Not only had she failed to repel the invasion, Adora was now gone. She was officially listed as killed in action but Lonnie knew better. She knew that Adora was out there somewhere with Scorpia, who had been branded a traitor.

Scorpia wasn't the only one who had been branded a traitor. While Lonnie had been recovering from her wounds, she had been brought a letter written by Kyle, one which stated his departure from the Horde for reasons he didn't explain.

Lonnie had been *devastated* upon reading it. She simply couldn't believe it. Kyle, *her* Kyle, had left the Horde? And worse still, he had left *because* of her? She had done everything in her power to keep Kyle safe and make him happy! Did he not realize just how many regulations she had broken on a regular basis for him? Did he not *care* that he was the brightest thing in her otherwise bleak world? He said that he loved her in his letter but, if he *really* loved her, he would be here now when she needed him the most!

When the soldier who had delivered the letter had left, Lonnie had grabbed her focus sword and let her rage flow. She had scored the walls, blasted away furniture, and smashed monitors. When her room was as ruined as the rest of the main compound, she had collapsed to the ground and wept for what she had lost.

This was all Adora's fault. She had put foolish notions of honor and doing what was right for the greater good in his head. The greatest good in their lives was their love and yet Adora made him think that there was something greater than that out there.

Lonnie *hated* Adora with every fiber of her being, she *loathed* her. Adora had been the one spirited away by the Mongrel King all those years ago, Adora was the one who got to no doubt live it up in Halfmoon, Adora was the one who got to experience love great enough for twenty Magicats to invade the Fright Zone just to rescue her, Adora was the one who was Shadow Weaver's favorite, Adora was the one who had Duncan's utmost respect—Adora had *everything* and had left Lonnie with nothing.

To think that she had once flirted with the idea of Adora being like a sister to her. To think that she had once considered Adora to be her best friend. To think that she had looked forward to the day the two of them would be Knights of the Fright Zone and stand side-by-side against the world.

She should have known that this would happen, she should have *known* that it would all fall apart. Everything that Lonnie and Adora were to each other was built on a bed of lies. Yet, despite that, she had let herself get close to Adora, thinking that it would all work out somehow. After all, they had been friends before Adora had been spirited away, right?

If Adora had truly been her friend back then, she would have insisted that the Mongrel King save her and Kyle and Rogelio. But no. She only allowed herself to be saved.

Adora. Perfect Adora. The golden girl. Shadow Weaver's protégé. Duncan's favorite. Scorpia's sister. Loved or respected by

all who knew her. The girl who had everything given to her on a silver platter.

The next time Lonnie saw her, she was going to kill her. No, worse than that. She was going to capture her and torture her and make her watch as Lonnie burned Halfmoon to the ground and executed the Mongrel King and all those there who loved her. Then, when a broken Adora would be begging Lonnie for the sweet release of death, Lonnie would look down on her and whisper "No." She would lock Adora away in the deepest cell in the Fright Zone and let her whither away into nothing. Then, and only then, would Lonnie's revenge be complete.

When her tears were spent, Lonnie pushed herself to her feet and wiped off her face. Adora had been winning their sparring matches more often than not as of late. If Lonnie wanted her revenge, she was going to have to get stronger. She was going to have to become more than Adora could ever hope to be no matter what it took. She would become the instrument of Lord Hordak's wrath upon Etheria.

With that resolve in mind, Lonnie picked up her focus once more and got to work.

The Black Garnet Chamber

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

It was weird seeing the Black Garnet chamber so barren. Lonnie didn't know what, exactly, had gone down in here that night a few days ago but she had *felt* how the magic had gone crazy. It was as though all of the magic on Etheria had been trying

to crash down on one place, as though Shadow Weaver had been attempting a Great Working.

Whatever it was that Shadow Weaver had been attempting that night, it had obviously failed and the result was that everything in the chamber had been either destroyed or irrevocably changed into something else. Even parts of the walls were being repaneled, the exposed piping and wires giving the chamber an almost skeletal look.

"Oh, good. You are already here," Shadow Weaver said as she glided into the room. It was almost impossible to tell beneath her billowing robes and her ever-present mask but she seemed a bit more gaunt to Lonnie.

"You summoned me, ma'am?" Lonnie asked, her voice neutral as she remained standing at attention. She had been waiting for a few minutes before Shadow Weaver arrived.

"Yes, I did. There are two things that I feel I must do," Shadow Weaver said as she drifted closer to Lonnie. "The first is that I feel I must… apologize for my behavior." She raised a hand and caressed Lonnie's cheek. Despite herself, Lonnie leaned into the affectionate gesture. "I had been neglecting you in favor of Adora ever since her arrival despite you being my star pupil. I never should have spurned you."

Lonnie *knew* that she was being manipulated, that Shadow Weaver wasn't *actually* sorry, but some traitorous part of her heart leapt at those words. "There's nothing to apologize for, ma'am. Adora was a new asset that simply needed more of your attention," Lonnie said almost automatically.

"Perhaps but, even so, that does not excuse my neglect of you, especially not when you still have so much to learn from me," Shadow Weaver replied easily as she withdrew her hand. Lonnie had to fight down the urge to chase after it and also the feeling of disappointment that it was already gone.

"You have been having difficulty finding a replacement focus, have you not?" Shadow Weaver asked as she drifted over to one of the few tables in the room. This one was covered by a cloth with something clearly underneath it. Whatever it was, it was long and slender. A staff, maybe?

"Yes, ma'am. My other duties have kept me from being able to find a suitable replacement," Lonnie reported.

"You need to look no further. It is time for the next step in your magical training and, for it, you will require a unique focus," Shadow Weaver said as she picked up the object from the table before holding it out towards Lonnie. "Take this."

Lonnie cautiously stepped forward and grabbed the offered item. Her brows furrowed in confusion as she could faintly feel celestial magic radiating off of it. Removing the cloth, Lonnie had to hold back a gasp at what she saw.

It was a wooden sword: a *kiari.* It was made from a beautiful wood that Lonnie knew to be *lauha* wood and had clearly been painstakingly crafted. Dropping the cloth, she tested the weapon's balance and found it to be flawless. There was only one person who this could have belonged to.

"Adora's *kiari?"* Lonnie asked, surprised by it.

"Her *original kiari,"* Shadow Weaver corrected. "It was taken from her upon her return to us."

"But, ma'am, this was made by Adora and is attuned to her celestial magic. It's basically worthless to me as a focus," Lonnie pointed out.

Shadow Weaver chuckled lightly. "Normally, you would be correct, my child. However, your training is no longer about using what was yours to begin with but *taking* what is theirs and making it your own. Just as I have taken the Black Garnet, you shall take that focus."

Lonnie looked up from the *kiari* and to her superior officer. "How do I do that, ma'am?"

"By becoming *more* than what you currently are. You use the Black Garnet's power via the Shards well but you have yet to truly be touched by it. It is time for you to become unshackled by what you were, Lonnie Leor, to instead become what you were truly meant to be. That is, of course, if you think you are ready."

Lonnie looked at the *kiari* in her hands as she thought. This was *exactly* what she had been wanting, wasn't it? Some way to improve herself beyond her current limits in order to catch up to and *surpass* Adora. Sure, she'd be playing into Shadow Weaver's hands by accepting this but wasn't Shadow Weaver offering the very thing that Lonnie wanted?

She was thinking about this too much. She had nothing left to lose and everything to gain. She would *take* what was owed to her.

"I'm ready," Lonnie said resolutely as she looked back up to Shadow Weaver.

Lonnie got the distinct impression that Shadow Weaver was smiling behind her mask. "Very good. I *knew* you were. Step closer to the Black Garnet, my child, and we will begin the process of making you anew. Do be warned, however, that this will not be a painless process."

"I can take it," Lonnie said as she did as she was told.

"I know you can. You are *strong,* my child. Strong in ways that few people can imagine and we shall make you stronger still. Now, hold up that sword and focus your magic into it. It shall act as the conduit between you and the Black Garnet."

When Lonnie did as she was told, Shadow Weaver held up her hands towards the Black Garnet. Magenta lightning lashed out from the RuneStone and into the *kiari* before spreading to Lonnie's entire body. She bit back a scream as she felt all of her

nerve endings flair to life. It felt like she was being burned alive from the inside out but she kept her eyes open and her mouth shut.

As Lonnie watched the *kiari* warp into something else, she felt herself change along with it. She felt her muscles expand, her bones grow denser, her skin become tougher, her senses become sharper. She could see not just the shape of the *kiari* change but also see the *magic* in it change. She saw how the celestial magic tried to stave off both the Black Garnet and Lonnie's own magic at the same time but, without the source behind it, that magic was soon swept up and changed into something far darker.

The seconds ticked by into an eternity as the process dragged on. Lonnie's own magic changed as it became more violent, like a storm roiling just beneath her skin waiting to be set loose. The Shards of the Black Garnet in Lonnie's hair and scattered about her body all pulsed in sync with her heart. Even the Tear of Fire that Lonnie had taken from that one Magicat changed as streaks of magenta shot through it.

After the process was complete what felt like *hours* later, Lonnie was left gasping for breath as her limbs trembled and her legs threatened to give out. Gone was the beautiful red wood of the *kiari* and in its place was a blade as black as night with swirls of magenta running through it. It was the perfect size and shape for Lonnie.

"You have done perfectly, my child," Shadow Weaver said, her voice sounding much clearer to Lonnie's now heightened hearing. "The process is a taxing one so go and rest for the day. Tomorrow, we shall begin your training anew."

Unable to speak, Lonnie merely used what was left of her strength to salute. She was the first, last, and *only* Knight of the Fright Zone and now she was something even greater still.

The next time they met, Adora wouldn't know what hit her.

Chapter End Notes

Zelenal: With this, *Knights of the Fright Zone* comes to a close and, with it, half of what could be considered Act 2 Part 1. Next up is the final chapter of *Heroes of Halfmoon* and then we'll be on to the next major fic in this absurd series of ours. I hope you've been enjoying the ride thus far and I hope you look forward to what's coming up next! I know that I certainly am.

tp9829: I would just like to state Lonnie is my new blorbo and thus I must put her in the torment nexus.

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